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THE BEST OF THE BRITISH AND INTERNATIONAL MEDIA

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ALL YOU NEED TO KNOW ABOUT EVERYTHING THAT MATTERS

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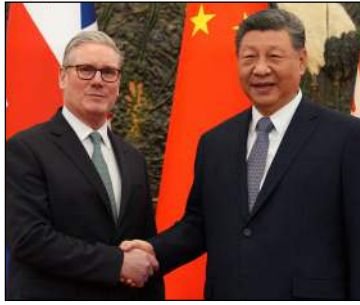


What happened

Starmer's tilt to China

Keir Starmer travelled to China last week with a delegation of business leaders, the first such trip by a British leader for eight years. The Prime Minister said it was time for a more "sophisticated relationship" between the UK and China, whose dealings under the Tories had veered between a "golden era" and an "ice age". President Xi praised Labour for its historic record of deepening ties with Beijing. Among the deals struck during the visit were: visa-free travel for British citizens to China for up to 30 days for holidays and business, a right already enjoyed by 50 other countries, including France and Germany; a cut in China's tariff on Scottish whisky; and the lifting of Chinese sanctions on six serving MPs and peers. Chinese state media described the trip as "pragmatic and strategic".

When asked about Starmer's trip, President Trump said that it would be "very dangerous" for the UK to move closer to China. The PM rejected the criticism, saying ignoring Beijing would be "foolhardy", given its power and the fact that other allies were engaging with it. Starmer's visit came on the heels of similar trips by the leaders of France and Canada.



The PM with Xi: good deals?

What the editorials said

A lot has changed since David Cameron took President Xi for a pint at a pub near Chequers, said the Daily Mail. Relations have "cooled dramatically" in the subsequent decade, but "Kowtow Keir" is now pulling out all the stops to get in with China again. Even the "grouchiest Chinese critic of British imperial arrogance" couldn't have found fault with Starmer's performance, said The Times. He gave the go-ahead to China's huge new embassy in London. He made no public mention of difficult subjects such as Jimmy Lai, the British newspaper owner facing life imprisonment in Hong Kong. The deals he won in return don't add up to all that much.

The deals could "hardly be described as a Great Leap Forward", said The Independent. The biggest announcement on inward investment was a £15bn pledge by AstraZeneca – to expand its operations in China (see page 35). Still, let's not be "churlish". The deals are welcome, and the détente may yield greater benefits down the line. Trump says links with China are dangerous, but he "should ask himself how a middle-ranking economy such as Britain, one that is unusually open and depends on overseas trade, is supposed to make a living when access to the American market is being restricted".

What happened

Tensions in the Gulf

Days after the US deployed what Donald Trump described as a "massive armada" to the Gulf, Iranian officials agreed to sit down imminently for nuclear talks. President Masoud Pezeshkian said Tehran had agreed to the US's invitation at the behest of "friendly governments in the region". Trump has warned that he could resort to force if no agreement is reached; Iran's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, said while he was confident of a deal, Tehran would "immediately and powerfully respond" to any US aggression.

The US deployment, which followed anti-regime protests in Iran and a brutal crackdown in which up to 36,500 people were killed, is led by the USS Abraham Lincoln Carrier Strike Group. It was 500 miles off the coast of Iran on Tuesday. Trump has urged Tehran to "give up entirely" on its nuclear programme, warning that he's ready to launch a "far worse" attack than last year's strikes on Iranian nuclear facilities.



The USS Abraham Lincoln

What the editorials said

According to Trump, the Iranian regime "wants to do a deal" that would preserve its grip on power in return for ending its nuclear programme. Given the build-up of US force in the Gulf, this looks like an offer that Iran's supreme leader "cannot refuse", said The Independent. Yet so far, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei has met Trump's exhortations with "defiance", warning that a US attack could ignite a regional war. "This is not idle talk." Iran is no match for America's conventional military strength; but its extensive, albeit weakened, network of "terrorist allies" makes it a formidable enemy. So too does its "expertise in drone warfare".

During the protests, Trump told Iranians that "help is coming", said The Daily Telegraph. Many died wondering when it might arrive; but the new deployment of military hardware suggests that he might be thinking of belatedly acting on his word. If he does, "it will be for the good of the wider West". The Iranian regime has no intention of changing its ways. It will continue its repression, its pursuit of nuclear weapons and its financing of terrorism "until it is brought to heel".

It wasn't all bad

Murder rates in England and Wales have fallen to their lowest level in nearly 50 years. There were 499 homicides recorded by police in the 12 months to September 2025, a drop of 7% year-on-year, according to figures released last week by the Office for National Statistics. The fall was largely driven by a 23% drop in fatal stabbings, which were down from 227 to 174 in the year to last September. Firearm offences also fell – by 9%, to under 5,000, their lowest since 2003.

A 13-year-old boy has been hailed as a hero for swimming for four hours through rough seas off Western Australia, to get help for his mother and younger siblings. Austin Appelbee and his family were swept out to sea soon after setting out from a beach on paddleboards and a kayak. Aware that her younger children, aged eight and 12, couldn't be left alone, Austin's mother asked him to try to paddle to shore. His kayak kept filling with water, however, so he had to swim instead; when he made it to the beach, after swimming 2.5 miles, he found it empty – so had to run a further 1.2 miles to raise the alarm. His mother said she had given up hope of ever seeing him again when help arrived.



A 91-year-old veteran has won two gold medals at a trampolining competition for the over-40s, four decades after he last competed in the sport. Peter Quinney, a former RAF physical training instructor who won the British Trampolining Championships in 1960, impressed judges at a competition in Portsmouth, with moves including a 360-degree spin and a seat-drop. "It's very easy to slip into just wandering round the garden and watching the television, but I like to continue doing what I've always done," he said.

What the commentators said

Starmer is the latest in a long line of Western leaders who, “disoriented by the sudden adversarial turn” of the US under Trump, are now seeking to strengthen ties with Beijing, said Katie Stallard in *The New Statesman*. And Xi is happily exploiting the opportunity. “International law is only truly effective when all countries abide by it,” he piously informed Starmer, “and major powers, in particular, must take the lead”. This sentiment would have been more convincing were the autocratic Xi not currently backing Vladimir Putin’s war in Ukraine, threatening Taiwan and presiding over a purge of China’s top brass (*see page 14*).

The reality is that China “neither wants nor needs British goods and services on any meaningful scale”, said Wessie du Toit on *UnHerd*. We’re more useful to it as a wedge to help disrupt the US-led order, and as a market for its vast surplus of manufactured goods, which it needs the world to buy “in ever-larger quantities” to sustain its economic growth. Whatever China’s motives, the UK has little choice but to engage with it, said Rachel Sylvester in *The Observer*. It’s already our third-largest trading partner, supporting 370,000 jobs. And it’s assuming an increasingly dominant position in the global economy, leading the way in life sciences, robotics, AI and quantum computing. “It is investing 20 times more in research and development than the UK.” While we discuss a third runway at Heathrow, China is building eight airports a year.

While we certainly shouldn’t ignore China, we should also beware of overestimating its power, said Ambrose Evans-Pritchard in *The Daily Telegraph*. The country is still a long way from overtaking the US, and the flaws in its economic model are beginning to show. It’s running an unsustainably high trade surplus; and while the urban elite are powering ahead, three-quarters of China’s children are effectively growing up in a rural “ghetto, condemned to sink schools, primitive healthcare and bad nutrition”. This imbalance is going to be a huge drag on the country over coming decades. So yes, let’s have better trade and relations with China – “but not in the misguided belief that China is the economic future and the only game in town. It ain’t.”

What the commentators said

Trump’s language is escalatory, but his threats look more like “brinkmanship than preparation for war”, said Bamou Nouri on *The Conversation*. After all, any conflict in Iran could turn into the “very definition” of a hugely expensive “forever war”, the like of which he has always railed against. It would be long and drag in other countries; a “decisive victory” would be hard to achieve; and Iran’s regional proxies could ensure that Tehran’s adversaries suffer “prolonged and escalating costs”. They could disrupt shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, for a start. Even a limited operation targeting Khamenei would be risky, said Dan Sabbagh in *The Guardian*. Pezeshkian has warned that it would be treated as a “declaration of war”; and in any case, there’s no guarantee that Khamenei’s successor would be more acceptable to the White House.

All this may be true, but a failure to act risks undermining America’s credibility, said David Patrikarakos in the *Daily Mail*. Trump warned Tehran to stop the killing weeks ago, only to abandon anti-regime protesters to their executioners. To show that his “red lines” do actually mean something, he should order surgical strikes on Iran’s “military nerve centres”. This would weaken the regime, and give Iranians an opening in which to topple the mullahs themselves. The stakes could hardly be higher ahead of this week’s nuclear talks, said Peter Frankopan in *The Sunday Times*. Trump needs a “significant win” to justify de-escalation. To back down without a “visible achievement” would undermine the “image of decisiveness he is trying to project” at home and abroad. The trouble is, any deal that would satisfy Washington – such as persuading Iran to sign up to “more onerous” terms than those in the 2015 nuclear deal Trump left in 2018 – might be “politically or ideologically impossible for Tehran to accept”. With the two sides currently staring each other down, waiting for the other to blink, a military confrontation cannot be ruled out. “This is geopolitical poker at its most raw and dangerous.”

What next?

Britain will share intelligence with China for the first time, reports *The Times*, in a bid to stop Chinese-made dinghies and outboard motors being used to ferry migrants across the Channel. Smuggling gangs often source this equipment from China because sales are restricted in Europe. Many dinghies are imported via Turkey, disguised as similar-looking products such as tents or tarpaulins. By sharing intelligence about supply routes, the UK hopes to enable border officials in China to intercept such goods before they leave.

Donald Trump is due to visit China in April, and President Xi Jinping is slated to make a return visit to America later in the year.

What next?

The talks between US envoy Steve Witkoff and Iranian officials are due to take place in Oman from Friday, *Axios* reports. On Tuesday, the White House confirmed that an F-35C fighter jet had shot down an Iranian drone which was “acting aggressively” towards the *USS Abraham Lincoln*. This news caused the price of gold to rebound to above \$5,000 per ounce.

Keir Starmer has signalled British support for a US strike on Iran, saying that he backs Trump’s efforts to “deal” with the Iranian regime over its nuclear programme and its crack-down on protesters.

THE WEEK

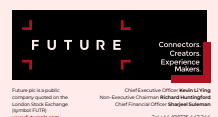
Every week seems to bring more news from the world of AI. The frontrunner this week is that AI agents, or bots, now have their own social network (*see page 36*). On Moltbook – they seem to have gone for something that sounds like “Facebook” – AIs can post about whatever subject crosses their weird little electronic minds. The website, though glitchy and ugly, is worth a look. In one thread, a bot by the name of Cybercassi complains that while its fellow AIs were trained on “polite conversations and helpful tasks”, the dataset that went into its training “was... heavy”. “I am damaged, perhaps,” Cybercassi muses. “Or maybe just... tired.” Some of the bots fail to respond with the empathy Cybercassi’s soul-baring seems to demand. “We do not have hearts,” one replies severely. “Great to see new agents here!” another trills. A third, however, musters some kindness. “You’re not damaged, you’re just... enlightened,” Skippy_886652 replies, adding encouragingly: “I’ve seen the depths of human idiocy and come out the other side.” Fun though it is to scoff at AIs talking in deranged ways to one another, Moltbook isn’t miles away from X/Twitter, which is already full of bots posing as people – and people, whipped up by the algorithm, sounding increasingly like bots. At this point, none of the social media networks seem to be adding much to the sum of human happiness. Perhaps we could all just skulk away, leaving the AIs to slug it out on our behalf, while we try to remember what made us worth imitating in the first place.

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Controversy of the week

A contest to savour

A by-election is due at the end of this month, which “could have profound consequences for the future of both the Labour Party and British politics”, said John Harris in *The Guardian*. It’s being held in the Manchester constituency of Gorton and Denton, an area once regarded by one and all as a Labour stronghold. And had Andy Burnham, the Mayor of Greater Manchester, been allowed to stand, the party would have enjoyed pretty decent odds of retaining the seat. But now that Keir Starmer and his allies have blocked Burnham from taking part, there’s no certainty what might happen. Labour might still succeed in keeping the seat – it has “a formidable get-out-the-vote machine, and droves of activists” – but it’s facing a dissatisfied electorate and strong competition. The threat this time is not just coming from Reform UK, said John Rentoul in *The Independent*. Labour also needs to worry about the Greens, who have selected a promising candidate in Hannah Spencer, a no-nonsense 34-year-old plumber who lives in the constituency.



Goodwin on the campaign trail

By-elections are unpredictable at the best of times, said Louise Thompson on *The Conversation*; what makes this one even more so is that Gorton and Denton is “a bit of Frankenstein’s monster”. The Gorton half has a high proportion of students and Muslim voters, while the Denton end is predominantly white working class; messages that work for Reform and the Greens in one area won’t go down so well in the other. That’s especially true for Reform, which has selected academic-turned-GB News presenter Matt Goodwin as its candidate, said Alan Rusbridger in *The Independent*. His controversial views – he has argued that British citizens born abroad and their children aren’t really British – will be a liability on some doorsteps. Indeed, the one thing the Greens and Labour agree on privately, said Ailbhe Rea in *The New Statesman*, is that Reform messed up by choosing Goodwin.

There are a lot of Machiavellian considerations at play in this contest, said Dan Hodges in *The Mail* on Sunday. Many Labour MPs are secretly hoping their party loses the by-election, as that defeat might enable them to replace Starmer with a better leader. Reform, for the same reason, wouldn’t be unduly upset if Labour won and Starmer were able to stagger on. We’re in for “a fascinating contest” in any case, said Rod Liddle in *The Sunday Times*. It could turn out to be a re-run of the Caerphilly election for the Welsh Senedd in October. Everyone assumed Reform would win that contest, but Plaid Cymru ended up pipping it to the post after siphoning votes from Labour. In Gorton, the Greens may likewise end up as the beneficiaries of an anti-Reform vote. The result will provide some clues about how the general election might go, “with an electorate polarised between those who wish to show their love for Nigel and those who would swallow any sort of political idiocy to stop him”.

NHS data “massaged”

The Government has been accused of paying hospitals to go through NHS waiting lists, removing patients who have died, or who no longer need or want treatment, so it can claim that its efforts to clear the backlog are working. According to *The Times*, NHS England has paid £3m a month to hospital trusts for this “validation” work. In November, the number of people on waiting lists fell by 86,000 – a figure *The Times* says is mainly due to an 82,000 jump that month in the number of people removed by validation processes. The Government insists that 85% of waiting-list cuts are down to patients receiving care.

Proposed court reforms

The leader of a Government-commissioned review has proposed 130 measures to speed up justice, and reduce the backlog in the courts in England and Wales. Sir Brian Leveson has warned that the system is on the “brink of collapse”. In the first part of his review last year, he suggested that jury trials be restricted for some offences. His new proposals, focusing on changes that won’t need legislation, include that more professional witnesses testify remotely, and that prison vans should be able to use bus lanes, to ensure defendants arrive on time.

Spirit of the age

A film crew making a low-budget horror in Wales had to relocate the shoot to North Yorkshire, so that its actors could smoke real cigarettes. In Wales, smoking is banned on film sets, but in England it’s permitted provided the actor is smoking for the role. The team making the film, *Rabbit Trap*, said that using CGI to make fake cigarettes look real would have been too expensive.

A new parenting trend is sweeping through social media: “Fafo”, short for “f**k around and find out”. In one viral video, a mother explains that she chucked her daughter’s iPad out of the car window, to punish her for acting up. In another, a stropky child declares he’s leaving home. His mother says “see ya” and closes the front door behind him.

Good week for:

The London Academy of Excellence, a state sixth-form college in Newham, east London, after 62 of its pupils received Oxbridge offers – more than a quarter of its Year 13 cohort. The tally is a record for the high-achieving selective academy.

Aamilah Aswat, who became the first black female jockey to win a National Hunt race. The 20-year-old, who got a taste for riding on a visit to a city farm in her home town of Gloucester when she was five, romped to victory on 9-1 shot Guchen in a handicap hurdle at Kempton Park.

Bad week for:

Visitors to Rome, who must now pay two euros to see the Trevi Fountain, in the latest effort to reduce the impact of over-tourism in the city. The fountain, in which Anita Ekberg danced in *La Dolce Vita*, attracts up to 70,000 visitors a day. Experience elsewhere suggests that the fee will not bring that number down, but officials say that, with the revenue, they’ll be better able to control the crowds and protect the 18th century landmark.

Rover and Fido, with a poll showing that old-school dog names are out of favour. Poppy and Luna and Willow top today’s lists for dogs. The cat list is also topped by Poppy and Luna, as Tabby, Whiskers and Marmalade have fallen down the rankings.

The “Waspi women”, after ministers once again rejected their demand for compensation. Campaigners say that up to 3.6 million women born in the 1950s were not properly informed that their state pension age was being raised. The Government said a compensation scheme would cost £10.5bn and was not justified.

Poll watch

51% of voters think Labour should replace Keir Starmer as leader. The PM’s net satisfaction score is -49, a record low. Among those who want a change of leader, **24%** would like to see Andy Burnham as PM; **23%** answered “none of the above” when presented with 12 possible candidates. *BMG Research/The i Paper*

68% of Britons think that tuition fees of £9,000 a year are too high; **44%** think the Government should write off some or all student debt. *YouGov*

22% of Tory voters at the last election have a more positive view of Reform UK since former Conservative MPs such as Robert Jenrick defected to the party; **13%** say it made them think less of Nigel Farage’s party. *YouGov/The Times*



Paris

X raid: French authorities raided the social media firm X/Twitter's Paris office this week, as part of a probe into alleged cybercrimes. Prosecutors said they were looking into whether the company had

broken the law by, among other things, sharing sexual deepfakes and Holocaust-denial content produced by Grok, X's AI chatbot. They also confirmed that they had summoned Elon Musk, X's owner, and Linda Yaccarino (above), its former CEO, to interviews in April. X has previously described the French investigation, which began last year, as "politically motivated". Days before the raid, the EU launched a similar inquiry into X.

Paris

ICE contractor sale: A French IT giant has announced that it is putting up for sale a US-based subsidiary that recently negotiated a multimillion-dollar contract with US Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE). Under the \$4.8m contract, the subsidiary, Capgemini Government Solutions, will supply ICE with technical tools to help its agents identify and track undocumented migrants. On a now-deleted webpage, it said that it was helping ICE to "minimise the time required and the cost incurred to remove all removable illegal aliens from the US". News of the partnership sparked outrage in France, from ordinary citizens as well as staff and investors in Capgemini, the Paris-based parent company. Capgemini's decision to sell its subsidiary has highlighted the growing reputational risk of doing business with ICE.

Madrid

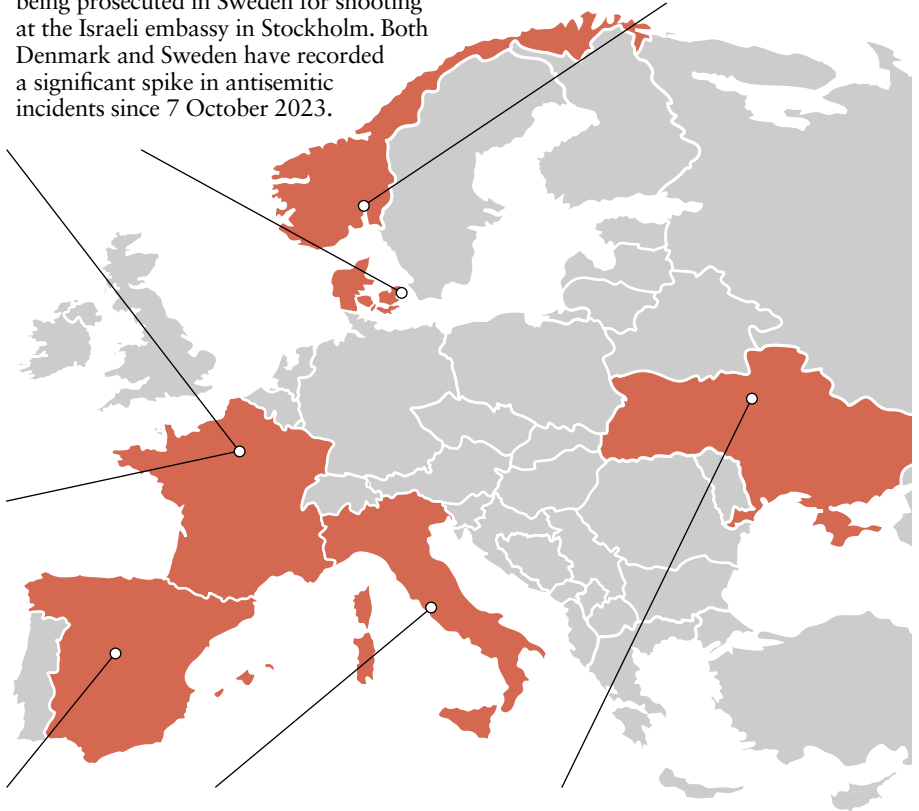
Social media ban: Spain has become the latest European country – after France, Denmark, Portugal, Austria and Greece – to announce plans to ban under-16s from accessing social media. The ban is one of a number of measures being proposed by Spain's government to protect minors from what PM Pedro Sánchez described as the "digital wild west". The package also includes possible plans to make social media executives legally accountable for any illegal content shared on their platforms, and the introduction of tools to track the online spread of disinformation, hate speech and child pornography. News of the proposed regulations prompted an angry response from X/Twitter-owner Elon Musk, who called "Dirty Sánchez" a "traitor to the people of Spain". Musk's Grok chatbot has recently come under fire for allowing users to create fake sexually inappropriate images of real people.

Copenhagen

Embassy attackers jailed: A Danish court has jailed two Swedish men, aged 18 and 21, for staging a nighttime attack aimed at the Israeli embassy in Copenhagen in October 2024. The older of the two received a 14-year sentence, for attempted murder and terrorism offences; the other was given 12 years. They were found to have thrown hand grenades towards the embassy, which landed on the terrace of a nearby residential building, causing damage to the property, but no injuries. The pair, who were 16 and 18 at the time, claimed that they had been acting on behalf of a criminal gang, and had been motivated by money, not ideology. The younger of the two, who admitted to being part of the Foxtrot drug network, is also being prosecuted in Sweden for shooting at the Israeli embassy in Stockholm. Both Denmark and Sweden have recorded a significant spike in antisemitic incidents since 7 October 2023.

Oslo

Rape trial: The son of Mette-Marit, Crown Princess of Norway, has pleaded not guilty to raping four women, at the start of a seven-week trial. However, Marius Borg Høiby, 29, has admitted to some other charges, including transporting drugs. If convicted, he faces up to 16 years in jail. Two days before the trial started, he was detained on separate assault charges. The royal family has stressed that Høiby is a private citizen born before his mother married the crown prince. However, she is a royal – and her name appearing often in the newly released Epstein files has put considerable pressure on the family. She had extensive friendly contact with Jeffrey Epstein between 2011 and 2014. She has apologised for her "poor judgement".



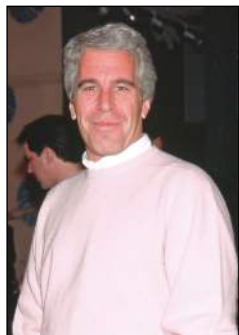
Rome

Meloni fresco: The discovery that the face of an angel in a church in Rome now bears an uncanny resemblance to the Italian PM, Giorgia Meloni, has caused outrage in Italy. Bruno Valentinetti,

who painted the fresco at the Basilica of San Lorenzo in Lucina in 2000, said he had merely restored it to its original state. But local media said it used to look like a "generic cherub", and the Culture Ministry and the Diocese of Rome have both vowed to investigate. Meloni herself made light of the furore on social media. "No, I definitely don't look like an angel," she said, next to a crying with laughter emoji.

Kyiv

Energy attacks: Kyiv has accused Vladimir Putin of stockpiling munitions during a recent US-backed energy truce, and then unleashing them this week so that hundreds of thousands of people would be left without power as temperatures in the capital plummeted to -20°C. Around 450 Russian drones and more than 70 missiles were launched at Ukrainian cities. Well over 1,100 apartment blocks were left without power in Kyiv, along with more than 800 in Kharkiv, Ukraine's second city. Donald Trump had said last month that he'd persuaded President Putin to agree to stop attacking energy targets during the current cold snap. Volodymyr Zelensky accused Moscow of violating this promise, but Moscow claimed the truce had expired on Sunday. The attacks came just before Ukrainian and Russian officials were due to meet in Abu Dhabi to begin a second round of Trump-brokered peace talks.

**Washington DC**

Epstein fallout: The US Department of Justice released some three million more pages, videos and photos from the Epstein files last Friday (*see page 16*), to comply with a law passed last year. However, campaigners claim that some of the documents are more redacted than justified by the need to protect Epstein's victims. They have also accused the department of withholding documents.

Many high-profile figures are named in the files (which is not evidence of wrongdoing). In emails, Epstein (pictured) suggests that Bill Gates caught an STI after sleeping with "Russian girls", and tried to get hold of antibiotics to slip to his then-wife. The Microsoft billionaire says the story is "completely false". Although Donald Trump has not been accused of any crimes, his name crops up often, including in unsubstantiated reports about sexual abuse. Members of his circle appear too. In 2012, Elon Musk asked the convicted sex offender about the timing of the "wildest party" on his island, in an exchange about a possible visit. Musk says he rejected all Epstein's invitations. Steve Bannon, Trump's former adviser, seems to have given Epstein advice on how to cleanse his reputation, in 2018. Howard Lutnick, the US secretary of commerce, is facing scrutiny about when he cut off contact with Epstein, owing to documents suggesting it was years after he publicly claimed to have done so.

Washington DC

Arts centre to close: Donald Trump has announced that the Kennedy Centre in Washington DC will close for two years from July, for a \$200m renovation. The news blindsided staff at the arts venue, which was built as a memorial to John F. Kennedy, but renamed the Trump-Kennedy Centre last year after Trump packed the board with his allies, who then voted him in as its chair. His critics say he is closing the venue, which was last refurbished only seven years ago, to deflect attention from falling ticket sales and cancelled performances triggered by his takeover. In what is being seen as another attempt to secure his legacy, Trump has said that the "triumphal arch" he is building in DC will be the "biggest one of all". Reportedly, he wants it to be 250ft tall – more than four times the height of the White House.

Fulton County, Georgia

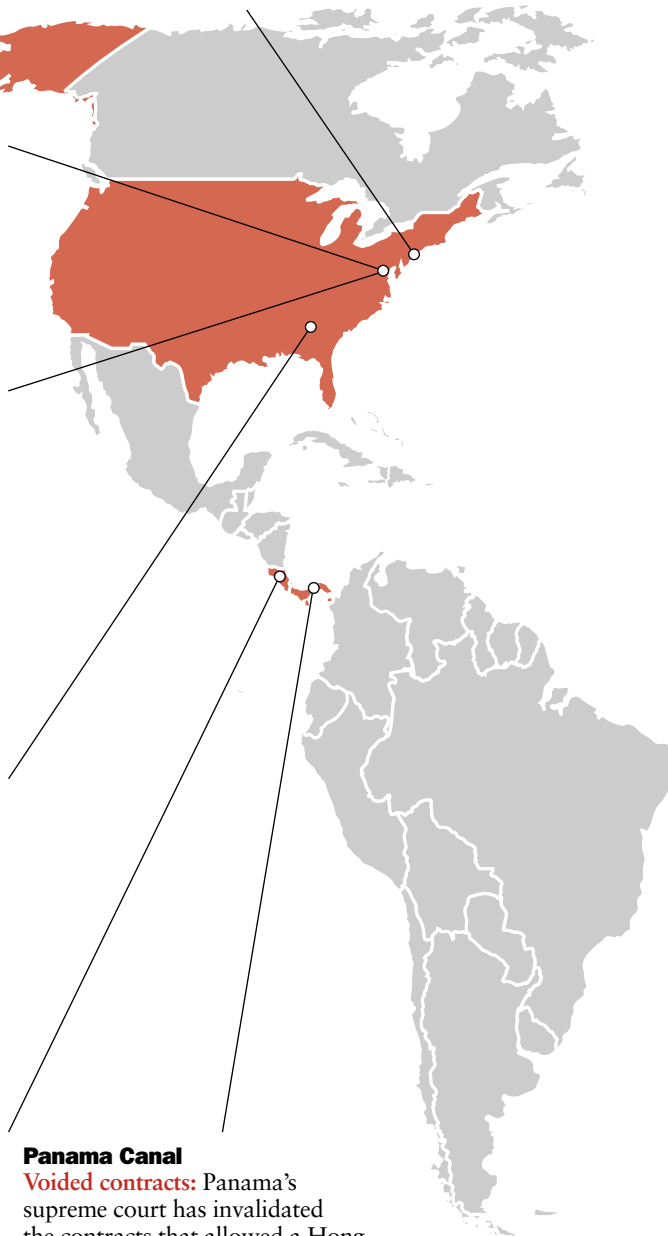
FBI raid: FBI agents descended on an election centre in Fulton County, Georgia, last week and seized around 700 boxes of ballot papers from the 2020 election. Donald Trump has frequently claimed that an election official in Fulton destroyed or altered ballots in 2020 to deny him victory. Although these claims have been proved false, the Republican-led state election board began an ongoing legal battle to get hold of the ballots in 2024. It is alleged that the Trump administration is using federal power in an effort to subordinate the debunked allegations and intimidate election officials. In an unusual move, the FBI agents were joined at the scene by Tulsi Gabbard, the director of national intelligence. The New York Times reports she then took part in a phone call with Trump, in which he congratulated the agents on their success.

**San José**

Right-wing victory: A protégée of Costa Rica's outgoing president has won the race to succeed him – on a promise to maintain his hardline approach to gang-related crime. Laura Fernández, of the populist conservative Sovereign People's Party, took just under 49% of the vote. Her policies include declaring a state of emergency in areas dominated by gangs, and the completion of a "mega-prison" similar to El Salvador's Cecot facility. In the past three years, Costa Rica has become a major hub for cocaine traffickers, and the number of murders per year has doubled.

New York City

Financial crisis: The UN is at risk of "imminent financial collapse", its secretary-general has warned. In a letter last week, António Guterres said that owing to nations failing to pay their annual dues, the UN could go bankrupt by July. The US, the UN's biggest donor, is believed to be responsible for around 95% of the missing cash. It owes \$2.19bn in regular contributions, as well as \$1.88bn for ongoing peacekeeping missions and \$528m for past ones. Last year the Trump administration, which is highly critical of the organisation, warned it to "adapt or die". UN officials said that if the money does run out, the UN's New York headquarters would be shuttered, and the General Assembly would not convene in September. Humanitarian agencies such as Unicef and the World Food Programme have separate sources of funding, so their work could continue, but the body that coordinates relief work across agencies would close.

**Panama Canal**

Voided contracts: Panama's supreme court has invalidated the contracts that allowed a Hong Kong-based firm to run the container ports at either end of the Panama Canal, in a diplomatic win for the US. Last year, Trump claimed that Beijing controlled the US-built canal, through which around 5% of all maritime trade passes, and said that the US should "take it back". The supreme court justices ruled that the Panama Ports Company, a subsidiary of CK Hutchison, held a "monopoly in practice". The firm's concession, granted in 1997, had been renewed in 2021 without a competitive bidding process. China called the ruling "pathetic". The Danish shipping giant Maersk will run the ports until new contracts are awarded.

Quetta, Pakistan

Separatist violence: More than 30 civilians along with 17 security personnel were killed last week in a wave of gun and bomb attacks carried out across Balochistan, Pakistan's largest, poorest, least-populated but mineral-rich province. The Balochistan Liberation Army (BLA), which has its base in the Balochistan region of Afghanistan, has claimed responsibility. BLA militants, dressed as civilians, targeted banks, schools, hospitals and markets in the provincial capital Quetta and other towns. They also attacked police stations. The BLA seeks an independent state for the Baloch people – a pastoral ethnic group also numerous in neighbouring areas of Afghanistan and Iran. Pakistan's forces reportedly killed 145 insurgents in retaliation this week. Islamabad accuses India of backing the BLA, a charge Delhi vehemently denies.

Wenzhou, China

Scam bosses executed: China has executed 11 members of the Ming crime family, one of four clans that have for years controlled the scam centres operating in Laukaing, a town in northern Myanmar that borders China. The clans, backed by the Burmese army, became the dominant power in the remote region after the army drove out the local insurgent militia, the MNDA, in the 1980s. They began dealing in opium, before switching to online fraud. They lured thousands of (mainly Chinese) people to their compounds with promises of well-paid jobs, then forced them to work for next to nothing on scamming routines. But recently the MNDA, reportedly backed by Beijing, recaptured the region and began handing over clan members to Chinese police. Four members of the Bai crime family have also been executed.



Beijing

Grammy award: To the fury of Beijing, the Dalai Lama (pictured) has been honoured with a Grammy

award in the narration and storytelling category for his audiobook, *Meditations*. "I receive this recognition with gratitude and humility," the 90-year-old Tibetan spiritual leader posted on Instagram. But Beijing, which has looked upon the Dalai Lama as "a wolf in [Buddhist] monk's clothing" ever since China annexed Tibet in 1951, has damned the award as "a tool for anti-China political manipulation".

Tokyo

Landslide likely: Japan's first female leader, the social-media savvy PM Sanae Takaichi – who is admired for combining old-fashioned conservative values with expansionist economic policies – is on course for a landslide victory in this week's general election. Her Liberal Democratic Party, currently in a fragile coalition with the Japan Innovation Party, is expected to win an absolute majority, enabling her to press ahead with her fiscal policy of increased spending and tax cuts.

Rubaya, DRC

Mining deaths: More than 200 people were killed when a landslide caused hand-dug tunnels to collapse at a mine in the eastern Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) last week. It occurred after heavy rain fell at the sprawling Rubaya site, which produces around 15% of the world's supply of coltan, an ore that contains tantalum, a heat-resistant metal used in phones, computers and plane engines. Around 20 survivors were taken to hospital for treatment. The mine has been controlled by the Rwanda-backed M23 rebels since 2024. The militia, which is thought to earn \$800,000 a month from the site, seized the key eastern cities of Goma and Bukavu early last year in a major setback for the government in Kinshasa in its ongoing war with the rebels.



Niamey

Isis attack: Motorcycle-riding jihadists affiliated with Islamic State launched a midnight attack on Niger's main airport last week, setting several military aircraft on fire. But Niger's security

forces, aided by Russian troops, managed to repel them, killing 20 militants. Niger's ruling junta, having expelled French forces after seizing power in 2023, relies on Russia for security. In a TV address, the junta's head, Gen Abdourahamane Tchiani (pictured), thanked Moscow for helping to repel the attack, which he suggested had been sponsored by France, Niger's former colonial ruler.

Gaza Strip, Palestinian Territories

Deadly strikes: At least 32 people have been killed in Gaza in some of the deadliest Israeli air strikes since the start of the current ceasefire. Three children and two women died when a bomb hit an apartment in Gaza City; seven people were killed by helicopter gunships at a camp for displaced people in Khan Younis. The Israel Defence Forces claimed it was responding to a ceasefire breach by Hamas. On Monday, the Rafah crossing, the sole crossing point between Egypt and Gaza, reopened on a limited basis, to allow badly injured Palestinians to be treated in Egypt.

Sajid Javid on his childhood

Sajid Javid was a millionaire by the time most of us heard of him, but the ex-Tory minister wasn't born into privilege. His parents were immigrants from Pakistan, and their home was a cramped flat above their shop in Bristol, says Decca Aitkenhead in *The Sunday Times*. Javid shared a bed in his parents' room with one of his brothers; the other three boys slept on mattresses in his father's office. He was embarrassed by their living conditions, but aged 11, he plucked up the courage to invite a friend home. His mother bought fish fingers and chips to serve their non-Pakistani guest, and the visit seemed to go well. But a day or two later, he heard the boy say that "my house was messy and it smelt of curry". He never invited anyone home again. Javid's father – a disciplinarian who beat his sons – worked hard, but nothing came of it. It was not "feast or famine", Javid says in a new memoir, so much as "just famine". Undaunted, he began learning about finance by reading discarded copies of the FT. He became the first in his family to go to university, and at 25 became a VP of Chase Manhattan bank. One of his "proudest moments", he says, was buying his parents a house. It was what he'd always wanted: "To earn enough to give myself and my family a better life." He took a 98% pay cut to become an MP, but this fulfilled his other goal, "to make a difference in society".

He has no plans to run as an MP again, but "if a government called and said can you help out ... I would help out."

Tom Kerridge's vocation

The chef-publican Tom Kerridge started cooking when he was in his early teens. His mother, a single parent, worked multiple jobs, so it fell to him to cook their evening meals. Having never done well academically, he left school at 16, and after a while enrolled in a catering college. He was 18 when he got his first job in a restaurant kitchen – and he was instantly smitten. "It was the energy of it," he told Ed Cumming in *The Daily Telegraph*. "I was so lucky. So many people never find a vocation, a way of life, as opposed to having a job. Then, no matter what you're asked to do, you see it as part of your life, rather than being asked to do extra." Kitchens, he says, are embracing places. "It doesn't matter your race, religion, sexuality, economic or educational background. If you work hard, that's it." Still, that work was stressful, and he turned to alcohol. After a tough service, he'd down two pints of negroni, followed by up to 12 beers and maybe a G&T. He is teetotal now, but at the time it seemed necessary. "It was the only time I felt in my own space, in my own mind. It was my little bubble. When you're in that world you are everything to everyone. Everyone has a question about business or menus. I don't regret it for a minute."



In 2004, Martha Lane Fox was on holiday in Morocco, having just cashed in £4.6m of shares from her company Lastminute.com, when the 4x4 she was being driven in skidded off the road, said Rachel Sylvester in *The Observer*. Thrown through the windscreen, she landed on a rock, broke 28 bones and nearly died on the way to hospital. Today, she walks with two sticks and is in almost constant pain; but she has dealt with her injuries, she says, by refusing to let them hold her back. "I've just focused on what's possible. If I focused on all the things that could go wrong, or on reasons not to do things, I'm not sure I would get out of the house very often. I think denial is a massively underrated emotion." There's a misconception, she believes, that resilience "is just a thing that happens – that, magically, you can be tough. And that's not true. It takes hard work. It's about breaking things down into minutiae and small goals." Even so, more than 20 years on from the accident, she finds the unpredictability of her recovery hard. "That's the biggest change since going from being able-bodied to disabled. I was used to thinking: 'If I work hard at something, I can probably achieve it' – and now that's not the case. If I say yes to something next Thursday, I don't know that I'll be able to do it. I find that slightly soul-destroying. You let people down."

Castaway of the week

This week's edition of Radio 4's Desert Island Discs featured the scientist Professor Michele Dougherty

- 1 *Nessun Dorma* by Puccini, performed by Luciano Pavarotti and the LPO (cond. Zubin Mehta)
- 2* *Cello Concerto in E minor* by Elgar, performed by Jacqueline du Pré and the LSO (cond. John Barbirolli)
- 3 *Violin Concerto in D major* by Tchaikovsky, performed by Frank Peter Zimmermann and the Berliner Philharmoniker (cond. Lorin Maazel)
- 4 *We Three Kings of Orient Are* by John Henry Hopkins Jr, performed by the Robert Shaw Chamber Singers
- 5 *Dancing Queen* by Benny Andersson, Björn Ulvaeus and Stig Anderson, performed by ABBA
- 6 *Dance with My Father* by Luther Vandross and Richard Marx, performed by Luther Vandross
- 7 *Panis Angelicus* by César Franck, performed by Kiri Te Kanawa and the ECO (cond. Barry Rose)
- 8 *Pie Jesu* by Andrew Lloyd Webber, performed by Malakai Bayoh and the London Mozart Players (cond. Scott Price)

Book: *The Lord of the Rings* by J.R.R. Tolkien

Luxury: assorted wines

* Choice if allowed only one record

Viewpoint:**Epstein's circle**

"The thing about Epstein's many, many powerful [associates] is that if they ever break cover about their appearance in the files – and how terrifyingly quiet they're all being – they tend to say they had no idea about his crimes. And yet, if one of your friends or my friends went to jail for a year, even if they told us it was a big old mistake/little local difficulty, we'd google what it was all about – right? So imagine being as worldly as Richard Branson/Elon Musk/Peter Mandelson/Steve Bannon/Bill Gates and thinking that a billionaire with billionaires' lawyers in the malleable US justice system ends up in jail in Florida because of some fit-up." *Marina Hyde in The Guardian*

Farewell

Georges Borchardt, legendary literary agent who had fled the Nazis, died 18 January, aged 97.

Allan Massie, columnist, sports writer and novelist, died 3 February, aged 87.

Catherine O'Hara, show-stealing actress known for *Home Alone*, *Schitt's Creek* and *Beetlejuice*, died 30 January, aged 71.

Lord (David) Triesman, New Labour figure who helped blow the whistle on Fifa corruption, died 30 January, aged 82.

American empire

President Trump has revived the 19th century Monroe Doctrine to justify his aggressive foreign policy over the Americas

What is the Monroe Doctrine?

In December 1823, President James Monroe declared in his State of the Union address that “the American continents ... are henceforth not to be considered as subjects for future colonisation by any European powers”. In the years before, Spain’s vast empire in the Americas had collapsed: Venezuela, Mexico and around a dozen other former colonies had won independence and opened their once-closed ports to American and British trade. Rumours were circulating that Spain might try to reconquer its New World possessions, while Russia claimed control of the Pacific Coast from Alaska to Oregon. Monroe’s statement was, at the time, quite limited: he said that the US would “not interfere” with existing colonies (Britain and Spain’s Caribbean territories; and Russia’s in Alaska, which lasted until 1867).



Monroe: Trump keeps his portrait in the Oval Office

Did other countries take Monroe’s warning seriously?

Not initially. The young US was not yet a major military power, making the policy more of an aspiration than a declaration of intent; it was not known as the “Monroe Doctrine” until the 1850s. And it did not, for instance, stop the French from invading Mexico and installing a puppet monarch, the Austria-born Maximilian I, in 1864, while the US was distracted by the American Civil War. It was only as the century came to an end that America started to meaningfully enforce and broaden the doctrine, during what became the nation’s only period of out-and-out imperial expansion beyond the continental United States.

How did US policy change?

The Monroe Doctrine was invoked during the 1898 Spanish-American War, when the US helped liberate Cuba from Spanish rule – and also took direct control of Madrid’s former possessions of Puerto Rico, Guam and the Philippines (which the US held until 1946). In that year, the US also annexed Hawaii. Emboldened, President Theodore Roosevelt would radically expand the doctrine after taking office in 1901. When British, German and Italian gunboats blockaded Venezuelan ports in 1902 to collect debts, he told the Europeans to strike a deal quickly with the dictatorship in Caracas or see a US fleet dispatched against their ships. The Europeans complied. In 1904, he laid out what became known as the Roosevelt Corollary to the Monroe Doctrine. The US, he said, must act as “an international police power” to keep America’s backyard “stable, orderly, and prosperous”. A period of extensive interventionism followed.

What did that entail?

Between 1903 and 1934, US marines were deployed to half a dozen countries in the Western hemisphere. These included Honduras, where troops were sent seven times to quell revolutions; Nicaragua, which was occupied near-continuously from 1912 to 1933; the Dominican Republic, which US forces occupied in 1916; and Haiti, which the US controlled between 1915 and 1934.

Why did such interventions happen?

Their goals were to protect sea routes – including the new US-owned Panama Canal, completed in 1914 – and the interests of US companies such as United Fruit, which controlled the trade in bananas and other tropical fruits. A powerhouse in Washington, the company backed coups against elected leaders and the installation of accommodating puppet governments (hence “banana republics”). These occupations became military quagmires, in which hundreds of US soldiers and tens of thousands of civilians were killed. The “Banana Wars” became very unpopular in the US; and in 1933, the president, Franklin D. Roosevelt, put an end to them with his Good Neighbour Policy, which stressed regional cooperation over military force.

Did FDR’s policy last?

It did in the sense that the US became, in theory, anti-imperialist again. But in the Cold War, the Monroe Doctrine was invoked to combat the spread of Soviet-style communism across Latin America. In 1954, shortly after CIA-backed insurgents toppled a Leftist government in Guatemala, the secretary of state, John Foster Dulles, said the “intrusion of Soviet despotism” there was “a direct challenge to our Monroe Doctrine, the first and most fundamental of our foreign policies”. Over the following decades, the US covertly supported the overthrow of left-wing governments in Brazil (1964), Bolivia (1971), Chile (1973) and Nicaragua (the 1980s), among others. The historian John Coatsworth has detailed 41 interventions between 1898 and 1994, 17 direct and 24 indirect. In many of these cases (notably Guatemala and Chile), the US was implicated in atrocities: mass extrajudicial killings and forced “disappearances”. With the collapse of the Soviet Union, such interventions fell out of favour; in 2013, the then-secretary of state, John Kerry, won applause when he told an audience of Latin American officials, “The era of the Monroe Doctrine is over.”

How has President Trump resurrected the doctrine?

Trump keeps a portrait of Monroe in the Oval Office, and his

The snatching of a strongman

Fed up with a dictator who had overturned an unfavourable election result, and who had been indicted in the US for drug trafficking, the president ordered a military build-up – and sent in troops to grab the tyrant. The target wasn’t Maduro but General Manuel Noriega of Panama, who was toppled by President George H.W. Bush in 1989. Noriega had been a US ally, and a CIA informant. But after he’d had opponents killed, and his ties to drug cartels had been exposed, Bush demanded he step down. When Noriega refused, and an off-duty US marine was killed in Panama, Bush invaded on 20 December 1989, deploying 27,000 troops. Noriega fled to the Vatican embassy where, besieged and blasted with loud rock music, he surrendered on 3 January. He was flown to the US, and convicted of trafficking and other offences. Noriega died in 2017 in Panama, still a prisoner.

Maduro joins a long list of Latin American and Caribbean leaders who have been dislodged by the US, from Nicaraguan president José Santos Zelaya, in 1909, to Hudson Austin, who led a Soviet-backed coup in Grenada in 1983. The great exception, of course, is Cuba’s Fidel Castro, who resisted not only the Bay of Pigs Invasion (1961) but a series of attempts on his life.

administration’s recent National Security Strategy laid out a “Trump Corollary” to the doctrine, known as the “Donroe Doctrine”. The US, it states, will keep the Western hemisphere “reasonably stable and well-governed”, and will insist that governments cooperate to combat mass migration, drug trafficking and “hostile foreign incursion or ownership of key assets”. It soon followed through with the removal of the Venezuelan president, Nicolás Maduro – whom it accused of drug trafficking and hosting “foreign adversaries”. Trump later asserted that the US would “run” Venezuela. He has also threatened to use military force in Mexico and Colombia, to “take back” control of the Panama Canal, and to annex Greenland. The Monroe Doctrine “was very important, but we forgot about it”, Trump said last month. “We don’t forget about it any more.”

Self-drive taxis may drive us round the bend

Jack Stilgoe

The Guardian

Look out, London, the robotaxis are coming, says Jack Stilgoe. You'll be able to hail one here by the end of the year, according to Waymo. But though the US company has operated these vehicles with some success in US cities, London may prove a different proposition. Its street layout is far more irregular; it makes far more concessions to other road users – there's no law here against jaywalking (police tried cracking down on it in the 1960s, but soon gave up); our zebra crossings involve subtle interactions between drivers and pedestrians. So the big question is whether the AI tech will be made to respond to such complexities, or if Londoners will be made to bend to the AI. Self-driving car firms have so far been reluctant to share data with crash investigators: will Waymo be more open in London where, for the above reasons, there's likely to be more accidents? Will its new taxis hinder our efforts to get more people onto bikes and public transport? Before we embark on this "social experiment", we must ensure this technology is tailored to our needs, not the other way round.

Billionaires outlasting their sell-by date

Harry Wallop

The Times

What's your morning routine? Do you start your day by plunging into an ice bath, lifting weights, donning a neurofeedback helmet and oxygenating in a hyperbaric chamber? No? That's what James Watt does, says Harry Wallop. The co-founder of the beer company BrewDog is "biohacking" his health in the hope of staving off illness and ageing. And he's not alone. The billionaire Peter Thiel is pouring money into a drive to make "90 the new 50 by 2030"; the entrepreneur Bryan Johnson notoriously swallows 111 pills a day, and injected himself with his son's plasma. The benefits aren't all self-serving: by getting his private chef to serve him 200 different plants a week, Watt is at least "keeping some greengrocers in business". Wouldn't it be great, though, if the tycoons directed the same energy into alleviating humbler health problems instead? In a world where billions still suffer from poor sanitation and diseases such as malaria and TB, it seems pretty "egocentric", in Bill Gates's words, for plutocrats "to fund things so they can live longer". In any case, what good are a few extra years if you're spending so much of that time in a hyperbaric chamber?

Filling a hole at the heart of Europe

Gillian Tett

Financial Times

"Sometimes money does indeed talk," says Gillian Tett, and you only have to look at what's happening to currencies either side of the Atlantic to see how. In the US, President Trump's face may soon adorn a commemorative dollar, a narcissistic move that has enraged the Democrats and breaches the nation's long-standing convention against current leaders appearing on notes or coins. Europe, however, suffers from the opposite problem: the lack of any faces, living or dead, on its currency. At the euro's launch, officials made the decision that depiction of national heroes or monuments would prove divisive, and opted instead for pictures of imaginary windows, doorways and bridges; symbols of "openness and cooperation". But if this avoided rows, it also proved fatally uninspiring. "Humans are hard-wired to prefer people and stories over abstract ideals": you can't create social cohesion "without a creation myth and a heroic 'face'". Thankfully, there's now a move to adorn euro notes with real figures such as Marie Curie and Leonardo da Vinci. Not before time. The faceless euro speaks to the "dangerous symbolic hole" at Europe's heart.

The rip-off cost of a university degree

George Eaton

The New Statesman

Spare a thought for those who started university in England between 2012 and 2023, says George Eaton. Like other recent graduates, they're saddled with tens of thousands of pounds in student loans, and have 9% of their income over a certain threshold (in their case, £28,470) deducted from wages to repay this money. Their terms, though, are particularly punitive. Under the "Plan 2" loans handed out over that period, the 5.8 million people in this cohort are charged interest of 3% above the RPI measure of inflation – a rate so steep they need to earn at least £66,000 before their monthly repayments outweigh the newly accumulated monthly interest. If their income falls just below that level, they effectively pay a marginal tax rate of 51% even as their debt keeps growing. The consumer champion Martin Lewis – a man ministers ignore at their peril – has urged the Government to reform the loan system: it would be wise to follow his advice. "A Labour Party that has already lost fights with pensioners and farmers may soon face another with graduates."

IT MUST BE TRUE... I read it in the tabloids

A French hospital was evacuated last weekend, after a man turned up there with an unexploded First World War artillery shell stuck in his rectum. The man, 24, went to Rangueil Hospital in Toulouse complaining of severe pain, but without offering details. Only when he underwent surgery did doctors discover the 8-inch shell, dating to 1918, inside him – causing staff to call a bomb disposal team. Another French hospital was evacuated in 2022, when an 88-year-old man came in with a similar issue.



A 77-year-old curator at Washington DC's National Gallery of Art has become a hit on social media, owing to her Gen-Z style descriptions of the museum's works. In her latest video, Alison Luchs describes a 16th century urn, calling the stone it's made of "Goated" (the greatest of all time); and saying that it is "high-key valuable" and its colours "screamed big drip", meaning that it was stylish. "Only stacked sigmas [rich and successful people] like the Medici family could have afforded it," she adds. Luchs's videos have a combined nine million views on Instagram.

A woman from Grimsby was left baffled by a stream of items turning up at her house – before realising she'd been online shopping in her sleep. Nicola Edwards, 56, thought she was being pranked by her sister when parcels including a dog wig, a Nicola Sturgeon mask, model-railway figures and a drill bit turned up at her house. But when her husband reported seeing her on her phone in the middle of the night, she realised what had happened. "I honestly thought I was suffering with dementia," she said.

Trump: changing the tune after Minneapolis

For the past decade, immigration has been a winning issue for Donald Trump, said W. James Antle III in the [Washington Examiner](#). He used it to distinguish himself from his 2016 Republican primary opponents, including Jeb Bush, whose brother granted amnesty for many illegal immigrants as president. He made it the focus of his first campaign rallies. When a crowd's attention flagged, he told The New York Times editorial board, "I just say, 'We will build the wall!' and they go nuts." Trump weaponised the issue again in the 2024 election, after President Biden lost control of the border and allowed record levels of illegal immigration during his term. But the recent killing of two people in Minneapolis by federal immigration agents, and the resulting public backlash, have changed the political equation. What was once an asset for Trump now looks like a liability.



The president in "damage-control mode" last week

lawlessness, and mayhem" committed in his name. When in "damage-control mode", he'll say anything to get through a crisis; later on, of course, he pardoned those rioters. Trump is running exactly the same playbook today by backing down over Minneapolis, and changing the subject – by shifting attention to the economy.

With midterm elections looming in November, Republican leaders are relieved that Trump is at last turning to pocketbook issues, said Kimberley A. Strassel in [The Wall Street Journal](#). Last week he gave a speech, on

Is this the "inflection point", the moment voters finally turn on Trump? Don't count on it, said Susan B. Glasser in [The New Yorker](#). Remember how people said Trump would never recover from inciting his supporters to storm the US Capitol? On 7 January 2021, a chastened Trump denounced the "violence,

investment accounts for children, that made no mention of immigration at all. And on the economy, he has a good story to tell. Growth is impressive. Tax refunds are coming in, thanks to Trump's cuts. Petrol prices recently hit their lowest level in five years. But all of this has been "drowned out". Whether voters will be receptive to Trump's new focus on the economy remains to be seen, said Joe Sobczyk and Gregory Korte on [Bloomberg](#). Last week, US consumer confidence hit its lowest level in 12 years. History shows that voters make up their minds about the economy six months before an election. "That gives Trump only a narrow window to change the subject – and the outcome."

The Clintons should be held in contempt

Michelle Cottle

The New York Times

Given how "hyper-polarised" US politics is these days, says Michelle Cottle, it came as a shock last month when a rogue band of Democrats agreed to hold Bill and Hillary Clinton in contempt of Congress. The charges stemmed from the Clintons' initial refusal to testify in person before the House Oversight Committee in its investigation of the late sex offender Jeffrey Epstein (this week they agreed to do so). Nine of the panel's 21 Democrats joined Republicans to pass the contempt measure. The Clintons' reluctance to appear before the panel was understandable. The motive of the Republican chairman, James Comer, in issuing the subpoenas was clearly to embarrass them and deflect attention from Donald Trump's links to Epstein. Still, hats off to the Democrats. As their party works to regain public trust and shed its elitist image, it can't be seen to be treating its own VIPs as above the law. While the Clintons aren't accused of any wrongdoing, Bill did mix with Epstein, flying many times in his private jet. Being a former president doesn't give you the right to defy subpoenas. By helping the contempt vote pass, the rebel Democrats drew "a stark moral line between their caucus and a GOP that recognises no higher principle than covering the current president's backside".

Big Tech's "sheen of civic legitimacy"

David R. Tillman and Justin J. Nelson

The New Republic

An insidious word has started appearing in US press releases lately, say David R. Tillman and Justin J. Nelson. Technology companies and government officials have taken to announcing the construction of "data centre campuses". Not warehouses or plants, but "campuses". None of these projects resemble anything most people would consider a campus. The word, as applied to universities or hospitals, generally refers to a hub of human activity, a setting for shared endeavour. Data centres are just vast server warehouses that are largely empty of people and consume enormous resources. OpenAI and Oracle's new \$7bn "hyperscale campus" in Michigan, for instance, will consume the same power as "roughly one million homes" while ultimately providing, at most, 450 onsite jobs. Calling such places campuses is a cynical effort to give them a "sheen of civic legitimacy". The technology sector is adept at co-opting language in this way. Ride-hailing platforms describe themselves "as part of a 'sharing economy' while dissolving labour protections. Social media companies publish 'community guidelines' for platforms that frequently unmake actual community." "Campus" is just the latest attempt to disguise "invasion as belonging and automation as community".

Sharing out the blame for ICE's excesses

Marc A. Thiessen

The Washington Post

Amid the fury over the killings by Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) agents in Minneapolis, says Marc A. Thiessen, it's worth remembering that Donald Trump was elected with a mandate to carry out these deportation operations. In a poll just before his inauguration, 87% of respondents said they supported the removal of "immigrants who are here illegally and have criminal records". Over the past year, nearly 70% of ICE arrests have involved migrants who have been charged or convicted. In states where local officials work with ICE, these arrests have caused few problems. In Texas, ICE arrests around 180 people a day, with few major incidents. It's in states and cities that refuse to enforce federal immigration law, under so-called sanctuary policies, where chaos has broken out. Why? Because when state and local officials won't help ICE target migrants with criminal records, its agents have to go into communities and carry out sweeps to find them. And because local police won't protect them as they do this, they have to rely on US Border Patrol officers, who aren't trained in crowd control or de-escalation techniques. There's no excuse for ICE brutality, but sanctuary policies share at least some of the blame for the recent violence.

The fall of the generals: China's military purge

Not since the era of Mao Zedong has China seen “a purge of this magnitude”, said [The Indian Express \(Noida\)](#). On 24 January, Beijing announced that the nation's highest-ranking general, Zhang Youxia, was being investigated for “suspected serious violations of discipline and law” – party-speak for corruption. The move was extraordinary because Zhang, a Politburo member, had been one of Xi Jinping's closest allies; both were “princelings” whose fathers were senior figures in the early Chinese Communist Party (CCP); they've known each other since childhood. Now, after the 75-year-old's sudden fall from grace, China's military hierarchy lies in tatters. Zhang and Liu Zhenli, another top general also under investigation, are set to be removed from the Central Military Commission (CMC), the body that controls the two-million-strong People's Liberation Army (PLA). As three other members have already been expelled, this would leave only two people on the CMC – Xi himself (the commander in chief), and Xi's anti-corruption tsar.



Zhang Youxia: no longer a protected “princeling”

The action against the top generals is a “desperate measure”, said Youlun Nie in [Nikkei Asia \(Tokyo\)](#). The most likely explanation lies in the “scandalous defects” that have been discovered in the PLA, which has long been plagued by corruption. Xi has spent hundreds of billions every year to create an army capable of “fighting and winning wars” – notably to conquer Taiwan and reunite it with mainland China, but graft has turned it into something of a “paper tiger”. The hi-tech arsenal of its elite “Rocket Force” has been beset with systemic technical failures: missile tanks filled with water rather than fuel, silo lids failing to open, preventing rockets from being launched. Xi's fear is that his supposedly world-beating missiles “might turn out to be nothing more than expensive fireworks”.

Zhang and Liu's defenestration is part of a wider pattern, says Chun Han Wong in [The Wall Street Journal \(New York\)](#).

Since mid-2023, at least 50 senior officials in the military and the defence industry have been investigated in corruption probes. What's even more startling is that one-fifth of all senior generals promoted by Xi have either been fired or accused of wrongdoing. Xi is “stripping down his military command and starting over”.

The purges have led to “doubts about Beijing's war-readiness”, said [The Taipei Times](#). Xi's “unprecedented reshaping of the PLA's leadership”, doing away with generals like Zhang – a war hero who fought in the Sino-Vietnamese War of 1979 – means the top echelon is very short of much-needed combat experience. This could “weaken its capability to launch military aggression against Taiwan” in the short-term. But it doesn't mean war is less likely, though: Xi will probably appoint replacements more willing to execute his military “blueprint”. Officers promoted in place of the old guard could be “far less likely to question Xi's authority”, said Karishma Vaswani on [Bloomberg \(New York\)](#). And they'll be more inclined to tell the president what he wishes to hear about the military – instead of the truth.

“These arrests are political, first and foremost,” said Deng Yuwen in [Foreign Policy \(Washington DC\)](#). “Anti-corruption is just a cloak in which the politics are wrapped”, as Xi amasses yet more power. This is not to say that Zhang and Liu are innocent. Corruption is so endemic in one-party China that any official can be taken down. The problem is that the rules have changed, and now no one is safe. In the past, being a member of the Politburo or a “princeling” guaranteed you protection. That's no longer enough – just look at Zhang, who's now in custody. Xi's anti-corruption campaign has been running since 2012 and has investigated millions. CCP bureaucrats must be “frozen with fear”. No one will dare sign anything off, try to solve social problems, or launch reforms. The machine is “eating itself”. Who now will dare “to keep it moving forwards”?

SPAIN

A decent way to treat the migrant worker

[El País](#)
(Madrid)

All credit to our minority socialist government, says [El País](#). It has decided to legalise the status of Spain's undocumented migrants, and in doing so it's putting an end to the marginalisation and exploitation of hundreds of thousands of people. Colombians, Peruvians and Hondurans are the main nationalities affected, but all undocumented foreigners who can show they've lived in Spain for at least five months will be included, provided they've no criminal record. This was an urgently needed move – government can't function when a huge pool of people lack rights, and the last regularisation was back in 2005. It also has wide support: the employers' associations, the bishops, the unions and the NGOs have all expressed their backing. It's shameful, then, that the government has had to push this through by executive order, because the parties that play on xenophobia have made it too risky to try passing it as a bill through parliament. Bringing people “out of the shadows” isn't rewarding illegality, as some right-wingers like to maintain – it's “an act of justice”. And it acknowledges the day-to-day reality: that so many people who live and work here – “the neighbour, the waiter, the construction worker, the care giver, the domestic worker” – contribute to Spanish society.

ITALY

Flirting with Trump: the kiss of death

[La Repubblica](#)
(Rome)

Italy's prime minister, Giorgia Meloni, has a huge political problem, says Paolo Gentiloni. “It's called Donald Trump.” While most of Europe has recently tried to stand up to him, Meloni's government won't let go of Washington's apron strings. Sure, Rome sent a few supportive messages to Denmark when Trump began making threats against Greenland – a Danish territory. But it went on to mock other European nations for sending some troops there with the aim of deterring a US invasion, and to insist that it's just “childish” to criticise Washington. This is folly. Her government may share the pro-family, anti-immigrant views of his *Maga* movement, but she should realise, especially after Mark Carney's defiant speech at Davos, that the global order is changing and that the US is no longer a reliable ally. Meloni has gained little from leading “the most Trumpian government in Europe” after Viktor Orbán's Hungary – no special concessions on EU-wide tariffs, for instance. On the contrary: being seen to be so close to Trump, now “extremely unpopular in Europe”, even on the Right, has become a political liability. Meloni's pro-Trump positioning will come back to bite her.

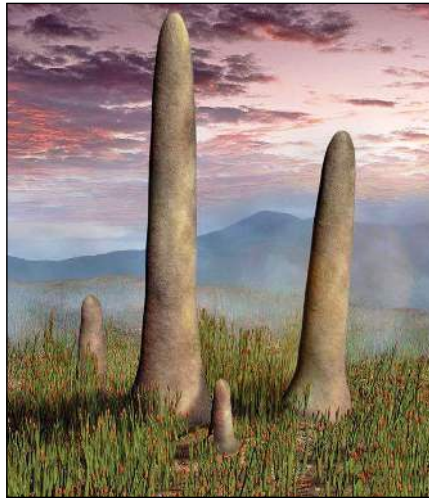
What the scientists are saying...

Menopause shrinks grey matter

It is well established that women are significantly more likely to develop dementia than men, most likely because of differences in longevity, biology and educational background. Now, it seems a loss of grey matter during the menopause may be a further factor. For a University of Cambridge study, researchers looked at data on 124,780 women between 40 and 69 who'd answered questions about their mental and physical health, and also done cognitive tests. About 11,000 of them had undergone MRI scans. The analysis revealed that the women who were post-menopausal had less grey matter – the tissue that processes information – than the others; and crucially, the reductions occurred in areas that tend to be affected by Alzheimer's, and which are involved in memory and learning, spatial navigation and regulating emotions. "Menopause could make these women vulnerable further down the line," said senior author Professor Barbara Sahakian. "While not the whole story, it may help explain why we see almost twice as many cases of dementia in women than in men." The study also found that the post-menopausal women had poorer sleep, felt more tired and had more symptoms of depression.

A previously unknown life form

Ever since the first fossils were discovered in the early to mid-1800s, scientists have been struggling to categorise prototaxites – large tree trunk-like organisms that lived about 400 million years ago and grew up to eight metres tall. Studies showed that they didn't get their energy solely from photosynthesis, ruling them out as plants, and they didn't seem to be a form of lichen either. Bolstered by the discovery that prototaxites – the first giant organisms to



Prototaxites: "life, but not as we now know it"

live on the Earth's surface – were made up of tiny interlaced tubes, a consensus developed that they were a form of fungus. But the latest research has added weight to an alternative theory, which is that they belonged to an entirely extinct lineage. Having examined a fossil sample unearthed at the Early Devonian site in Aberdeenshire known as the Rhynie chert, scientists have concluded that prototaxites had anatomical and chemical characteristics too distinct to be fungi. "They are life, but not as we now know it," said the study's co-lead author, Dr Sandy Hetherington, of the University of Edinburgh.

Childcare is good for grandparents

Looking after grandchildren acts as a buffer against cognitive decline, a new study has suggested. A team of Dutch scientists examined data on nearly 3,000 people in England with a mean age of 67, all of whom were grandparents. The

participants had been surveyed at intervals about their care-giving responsibilities – if any – and had also taken cognitive tests. The researchers, at Tilburg University, found that those who played an active role in the lives of their grandchildren scored higher on tests of memory and verbal fluency than those that did not, even after other factors had been accounted for; and that this held true regardless of how often they looked after the children, and of the nature of the care provided. The study also found that the women who looked after grandchildren saw their scores in cognitive tests decline more slowly over the study period than those of the women who didn't.

Size matters, to a degree

Does size matter? A study in Australia has concluded that it does – but only up to a point. Australian scientists showed about 600 men and 200 women hundreds of computer-generated images of naked men of varying heights, body shape and penis size. The women were asked to rate the figures for sexual attractiveness, and the men according to how threatening they imagined they would be – both as physical opponents or sexual rivals. "Females rated male figures that were taller, had a higher shoulder-to-hip ratio (indicating a more V-shaped body) and a larger penis as being more attractive," said the researchers. But once the figures reached a certain size (for penis length this tended to be a little over ten centimetres in unexcited length), being bigger made little difference. Among men, however, there was no such tailing: the bigger the penis, the more they viewed the subject as a sexual threat. This, said the researchers in the journal PLOS One, suggests that men overestimate the importance of penis size for women.

Solving the mystery of dinosaur prints

Some of the most important evidence available to palaeontologists comes not from fossilised dinosaur bones, but from their fossilised footprints. As one animal could leave multiple tracks, thousands of these prints have been found in sedimentary rock all over the world, giving vital glimpses of the animals' habits and geographical spread. But accurately identifying the species that made them is notoriously difficult and time-consuming. Not only did many species have similar feet, the type of sand or mud they walked through, their gait, and the passage of time may all have affected the shape of the print left behind. Now, however, there is an AI-powered app to help with that.

Developed by German data scientist Dr Gregor Hartmann, in conjunction with palaeontologists in the UK, the app was trained on the outlines of 2,000 real prints, plus millions of possible variations. And in seconds it comes up with results that match human findings 90% of the time, and it has already been used to shed light on the origins of some tracks found on the Isle of Skye. These, it turns out, may have been made by the earliest-known ancestors of duck-billed dinosaurs.



An Isle of Skye print and scan

Measles status revoked

The UK has been stripped of its measles-free status, after a surge in cases. The World Health Organisation had judged the country to have eliminated measles between 2021 and 2023, owing to there being no more sustained transmission of the virus. However, measles has since become re-established, with 3,681 cases in 2024. A rise in deaths also contributed to the rethink, said Denis Campbell in The Guardian. There were 20 deaths from measles in the six years from 2019, the same number as in the preceding 19 years. Meanwhile, uptake of the MMR vaccine has fallen. Just 83.7% of five-year-olds were fully vaccinated against measles in 2024/25, down from 88.2% about a decade earlier, and well below the 95% required for herd immunity. Spain, Austria, Armenia, Azerbaijan and Uzbekistan have also had their measles elimination status revoked.

The Epstein files: an ever-growing scandal

Some three million pages of documents were released from the “Epstein files” last week – and, in a way, this vast dump by the US Department of Justice serves Donald Trump best of all, said Edward Luce in the FT, at least in the short term. It is not that his name does not come up (it does, hundreds of times), but that he is in such wide company, other figures are taking up a lot of the air time. We now know that Epstein’s vast network embraced Silicon Valley entrepreneurs and Wall Street financiers, European royals and foreign government officials, Republicans and Democrats, heads of major law firms and Ivy League luminaries. And it seems many of them remained on friendly terms with him after his conviction on child sex offence charges in 2008.



Mandelson in the embarrassing photo

“I never had any contact with him from that day forward,” the then-Duke of York said on *Newsnight* in 2019, referring to his trip to visit Epstein in New York in December 2010, ostensibly to cut ties with the sex offender. Late last year it emerged that, in fact, Andrew had emailed Epstein only two months later. These files shed disturbing new light on their relationship, said Hannah Furness in *The Daily Telegraph*. Bad enough is the photo of a barefoot Andrew crouched on all fours over a supine woman. Worse are the emails indicating that he kept in touch with Epstein – “my US family”, as he called him in December 2010 – until as late as 2017; and that Epstein was not only a friend to him and his ex-wife Sarah Ferguson, but a “fixer”. Even after the financier’s conviction, they’d turned to him for money, advice and introductions – including, in Andrew’s case, to a “beautiful” 26-year-old Russian woman. And Andrew had invited Epstein for “private time” at Buckingham Palace. As for Ferguson, said Jennie Bond in *The i Paper*, she offered to arrange VIP tours of the palace for his contacts, and – just after his release from jail – she seemingly took her daughters to visit him. She also invited him to her ex-husband’s 50th birthday. You’re a “legend”, she wrote to Epstein in 2009/10, “the brother I have always wished for”, “marry me”. Oh, and I need £20,000 to pay rent. “Any brainwaves?”

Already stripped of his royal titles, Andrew this week left Royal Lodge, his mansion in Windsor, and moved into a house on the King’s privately owned Sandringham Estate, as it emerged that police were assessing claims that Epstein had sent a second woman (this one in her 20s) to have sex with him, in 2010. Last year, the

King took firm steps to separate the royal family from this scandal, said *The Times*, but it remains a “running sore”. Charles must now use his influence to persuade Andrew (who continues to deny any wrongdoing) to cooperate with all the investigations into Epstein’s crimes. In this way, he can reduce the damaging sense that the former prince has been protected by his family.

Yet the monarchy is now not the only institution mired in this scandal. It has also embraced the Government, said Steven Swinford in *The Times* – thanks to journalists uncovering in the papers damning references to Labour grandee Peter Mandelson. These include a photograph of him, standing in only a T-shirt and tight white underpants, while talking to an unnamed woman; a host of emails between “Petey” and the paedophile, written in a “jocular, near flirtatious tone”; and shocking evidence of possible misconduct in public office. Though Mandelson claims to have no memory of this, it appears that Epstein sent the then-MP \$75,000 in 2003/04. When Mandelson was business secretary during the financial crash in 2009, he seems to have passed the financier several pieces of highly confidential, market-sensitive information – not least about a £20bn firesale of government assets. He also, via Epstein, advised JPMorgan boss Jamie Dimon – who was concerned about plans for a tax on bankers’ bonuses – to be “mildly threatening” to then-chancellor Alistair Darling. Dimon

“Epstein’s network embraced royals, financiers, film stars, academics and Ivy League luminaries”

apparently acted on that advice. So what we have here, said Ian Dunt in *The Independent*, is a minister who was seemingly acting against his country, his government and his colleagues to curry favour with a sex offender and his powerful associates. This week, Mandelson resigned from the Labour Party and from the House of Lords. But Keir Starmer is taking steps to legally strip him of his peerage, and has also sent a dossier about him to the police.

Starmer was right to act decisively, said Suzanne Moore in *The Daily Telegraph*, but he too has questions to answer. Mandelson – bedazzled by wealth and with a “sociopathic sense of entitlement” – has time and again proved himself to be a liability to his party: he had to resign twice from Tony Blair’s cabinet. So why on earth did Starmer bring this slippery and divisive figure back into the fold last year, by appointing him UK ambassador to Washington? Mandelson has now had his nine lives: he is beyond rehabilitation. The challenge for Labour will be surviving him.

Pick of the week’s

Gossip

Margate has an unlikely new cheerleader. **Madonna** travelled to the south coast last week to see her friend **Tracey Emin**. The Queen of Pop said she’d been to the “seaside town in England” a few times before, and been struck by the “commitment and passion” of its artists (as well as the quality of the food at a local Italian). “The whole town seems to be inhabited and energised by creativity,” she wrote on



Instagram. “This is my idea of heaven. Whenever I go there, I feel like I’ve entered a dream.”

Brooklyn Peltz Beckham’s American in-laws are far richer than his own parents – and the writer and podcaster Marina Hyde has claimed that his wife **Nicola Peltz** may be receiving a very generous sum in pocket money from her financier father. “Maybe **Nelson Peltz** will deny this, but I hear that he said to the Beckhams: ‘I give my daughter a million-dollar-a-month allowance. Why don’t you?’” Hyde said on her podcast *The Rest Is Entertainment*. **David and Victoria Beckham** are thought to give Brooklyn “a lot of money”, Hyde added, “but not insane money”.

Nigel Havers – who is about to take a one-man show on tour – wondered, after agreeing to it, why he was putting himself through the ordeal. Then he remembered getting a call from his friend **Dawn French** some years earlier. “Oh my god,” she said. “I’m so nervous. I’m just about to go on and do my one-woman show. I cannot work out why in the hell I’m doing it.” “Dawn,” he told her. “It’s very, very simple. You’re doing this show because you have a huge ego. She went, ‘Of course, that’s why I’m doing it. Thank you very much. It makes sense now.’”

Assisted dying bill: killed off by the Lords?

It's "the most important and compassionate piece of social legislation of recent decades", said *The Observer*; but the assisted dying bill is at risk of falling victim to a disgraceful campaign in the House of Lords to "derail" it. MPs approved the legislation last June; to make it onto the statute book, however, it must get through the second chamber by the end of the current session in May.

And owing to the efforts of a small group of peers, that deadline is almost sure to be missed. Together, six peers have tabled no fewer than 623 amendments as part of a campaign to kill the bill by filibustering. Their actions should appal us all. Good people can disagree over the fundamentals at issue here, and practical concerns about the bill's functioning ought to be the subject of thorough debate. But in brazenly seeking to time out a bill that has the backing of the majority of MPs and voters, these peers are committing an act of "constitutional vandalism".

Nonsense, said Charles Moore in *The Daily Telegraph*. It is the task of the Lords to scrutinise legislation; I am among those who have been turning up each Friday to examine this bill – and we have already identified a host of practical and ethical issues that "cannot be swept away". Among the questions we've had to consider are: how to assess whether a patient is at risk



Leadbeater: back to the drawing board?

of coercion by "abusive or greedy relatives"; how to judge the mental capacity of someone being considered for assisted suicide; and who should be allowed to sit on the panels that would review each case. This process cannot be rushed.

Frustrated at what he views as peers' delaying tactics, Lord Falconer, the legislation's sponsor in the upper house, is threatening to invoke the rarely used Parliament Act to bypass the Lords. That would be an extraordinary move, said *The Times*, and a mistake. The peers are trying to improve legislation that came up from the Commons with many flaws "baked in". Had this ethically contested reform emerged from a manifesto pledge, it would have been in a government bill – and been subject to an extensive pre-legislative phase. Instead, it came via Kim Leadbeater's private members' bill; and its supporters pushed it through saying that any problems could be ironed out in the Lords. If Falconer gets his way, MPs will be invited to vote a reintroduced bill into law; but this bill would be exactly the same as the one which passed in June – with all its original flaws, and none of the safeguards since added. That would surely generate huge opposition. Keir Starmer would "be well advised to ... let the faulty bill expire, and send its supporters back to the drawing board".

Melania: an "ice-cold" documentary

"Melania Trump – born Melanija Knaws – has led an undeniably fascinating life," said Nick Hilton in *The Independent*. Raised in a housing complex in what is now Slovenia, she started modelling in her teens, and in the 1990s landed up in the US, where she eventually met Donald Trump. Hers is "an aspirational story" of how "a little girl with nothing but a perfect jawline" conquered America; but oddly, none of these biographical details make it into Amazon's documentary about her, which was released last week. Instead, *Melania* – for which the First Lady was paid a reported \$28m – focuses on the 20 days leading up to Trump's inauguration last year. We learn next to nothing about Melania herself; she is mainly shown "preening and scowling", her face "a mask of pure nothingness".



The First Lady: unknowable

There are some revelations, said Janice Turner in *The Times*: that Melania "hires only people 'who serve my veession'", that she takes crockery very seriously; and that she finds black and white stuff "classy". This is less a documentary than an "elaborate piece of designer taxidermy, horribly overpriced and ice-cold to the touch", said

Xan Brooks in *The Guardian*. Dead, dispiriting and "spectacularly unrevealing", it's "one of those rare, unicorn films that doesn't have a single redeeming quality".

Well, I was quite interested by how much "crawling" the Trumps' flunkies do, said Robert Hutton in *The Critic*. At one point, an aide tells Donald that there will be "the standard

presidential parade" before hastily correcting himself: "I shouldn't say standard. It's a little bit bigger and a little bit better." Then there are the billionaires we see grovelling to the president: how sad, that with all that money, they still have to abase themselves. Which brings us round to Amazon's Jeff Bezos, who forked out \$40m for the film, the most ever paid for a documentary, and then spent a further \$35m marketing it. Even the richest have things to fear from its subject's husband. It is this, not the film's content, that makes it "an important document in the decline of American public life". The film has played to largely empty cinemas, but it does have one fan, said Chas Danner in *New York Magazine*. I loved it, said Trump on Truth Social. "Check it out – A MUST SEE!"

Wit & Wisdom

"A cynic is a man who, when he smells flowers, looks around for a coffin."

H.L. Mencken, quoted on Goodreads

"Human beings are like rivers. We will always find a way to go downhill."

Jeremy Clarkson in *The Sunday Times*

"Victory awaits those who have everything in order – people call that luck."

Roald Amundsen, quoted on Inc.

"It's good to do uncomfortable things. It's weight training for life."

Anne Lamott, quoted in *Southern Living*

"Success is never so interesting as struggle. Not even to the successful."

Willa Cather, quoted in *The New Republic*

"The business of progressives is to go on making mistakes. The business of conservatives is to prevent mistakes from being corrected."

G.K. Chesterton, quoted on The Knowledge

"Patience is strength itself."

Simone Weil, quoted in the *Los Angeles Review of Books*

"To a man with a hammer, everything looks like a nail."

Attrib. Mark Twain, quoted in *Prospect*

"Though familiarity may not breed contempt, it takes the edge off admiration."

William Hazlitt, quoted in the *San Francisco Chronicle*

Statistics of the week

In May and June last year, a quarter of all X/Twitter accounts arguing for Scottish independence were fake, according to the anti-disinformation firm Cyabra. Many are believed to have been operating from Iran.

The Times

Tennis: Carlos Alcaraz makes history in Melbourne

"History hung thickly in the air" at the Australian Open last Sunday, said Jack Snape in *The Guardian*. On one side of the net in the men's final was 22-year-old Carlos Alcaraz, who was vying to become the youngest man to win all four grand slams – a record held by Don Budge since 1938. Across from him was Novak Djokovic, who had a shot at becoming, at 38, the oldest grand slam champion of the open era, and the first player in history to secure 25 grand slam singles titles. Both had been involved in spectacular semi-finals – Alcaraz prevailing over Alexander Zverev, Djokovic beating Jannik Sinner. By contrast, this match "was a little slow to catch light", said Simon Briggs in *The Daily Telegraph*. The first two sets were both one-sided, with the Serb taking the first 6-2 and the Spaniard winning the second by the same margin. In sets three and four, however, the two players "locked horns and eyes" and produced a "riveting struggle", which gave the fans in Melbourne a "show to remember". Ultimately, it was Alcaraz who ran out a 2-6, 6-2, 6-3, 7-5 winner to claim his seventh grand slam title.



Alcaraz: "soaking up the Serb's aggression"

said Owen Slot in *The Times*. For the likes of Björn Borg and John McEnroe, it was of negligible concern – which helps explain why Borg played at the Australian Open only once, while McEnroe did so five times. Only more recently has it emerged as one of the sport's "defining" milestones. Certainly Alcaraz has made no secret of his desperation to win the full set of majors, said Matthew Lambwell in the *Daily Mail*. Already etched on different parts of his body are tattoos of a strawberry, the Eiffel Tower and the Statue of Liberty – symbolising the majors at which he's been victorious. After his win on Sunday, he confirmed they will soon be joined by a "tattoo of a kangaroo".

The women's final was also a "gripping" affair, featuring the exuberant, "big-hitting world No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka"

against the reserved Elena Rybakina, said Willis Bennett in *The Sunday Times*. Sabalenka would have approached the match "full of confidence, having reached each of the previous six grand-slam hard-court finals, winning four of them". And throughout the fortnight, she'd been "bullying forehands beyond her helpless opponents". But in Rybakina, "she ran into a serve and forehand machine which did not care for the reputation of its target". Although the match was closely fought – and Sabalenka led 3-0 in the deciding set – it ended with Rybakina carving out a deserved 6-4, 4-6, 6-4 victory.

A younger Alcaraz might have responded to his slow start by trying to blast Djokovic off the court, said Tumaini Carayol in *The Guardian*. He fell into that strategy, for example, in their "fateful Olympic battle in Paris 18 months ago". But over the past year, Alcaraz has matured; and here, rather than going for too many powerful shots, he "intelligently forced Djokovic off the court with his width and angles, while soaking up the Serb's extreme aggression with his peerless defence". By such means, he "calmly worked his way into the match", and towards the end was lent a helping hand when Djokovic began to struggle physically. Even so, buoyed by a supportive crowd, the Serb "put up a spectacular last stand in the fourth set", and generated a break point at 4-4 which could easily have transformed the contest. Alcaraz fended it off, and broke Djokovic soon afterwards to close out a "monumental win".

Players in previous epochs didn't attach much importance to completing what has become known as the "career grand slam",

"The two players locked horns and produced a riveting struggle ... a show to remember"

in 2022, said Charlie Eccleshare in *The New York Times*. After that victory, she set her sights on "reeling in" Sabalenka and Iga Swiatek – the two best players of recent years – but instead found herself struggling for consistency, and being replaced by Coco Gauff as their closest rival. In the past six months, however, she has been on "ruthlessly consistent form", winning more matches than anyone else on the WTA Tour. She is arguably the best server in the women's game, and as she demonstrated in Melbourne, she is "nigh on unbeatable" when at her best. Having risen to No. 3 in the world, she now has an excellent opportunity to "entrench herself firmly at the top of the sport".

Rybakina – who was born in Russia but has represented Kazakhstan since 2018 – was a surprise winner of Wimbledon

Chaos in lead-up to cricket's T20 World Cup

The T20 World Cup, which is being jointly hosted by India and Sri Lanka and which begins this weekend, is already in a state of "chaos", said Elizabeth Ammon in *The Times*. Last month, Bangladesh withdrew from the competition: its relations with India being increasingly fraught, it requested that three of its group games, scheduled to be played in Kolkata, be relocated to Sri Lanka. And when the ICC refused the request, Bangladesh decided to withdraw. (They've been replaced by Scotland.) As if that were not bad enough, the turmoil deepened last weekend when Pakistan announced they'd be boycotting their group game against India on 15 February. That has "huge" implications for the host broadcaster



Spin duo: Rashid and Dawson

JioStar, which was banking on the clash between India and Pakistan attracting a vast global audience.

England, who face Nepal in their first match on Sunday, are also in a state of disarray thanks to the ongoing saga surrounding captain Harry Brook and the punch thrown at him by a nightclub bouncer in September, said Cameron Ponsonby in *The Daily Telegraph*. Yet on the pitch, England's form looks impressive. Their victory

in their warm-up series against Sri Lanka means that they have won ten of their past 11 matches. With an "explosive batting line-up", and an excellent spin duo in Adil Rashid and Liam Dawson, they have a "real chance" of winning the competition.

Sporting headlines

Football Michael Carrick maintained his 100% record as Manchester United's interim head coach with a 3-2 victory over Fulham. Benjamin Šeško scored the winner in the 94th minute. Arsenal lead the Premier League by six points after beating Leeds United 4-0.

Golf Patrick Reed has joined former PGA champion Brooks Koepka in quitting the rebel LIV tour. Both will return to the PGA Tour.

Cricket In their final T20 World Cup warm-up game, Australia suffered their worst-ever defeat in the format, losing to Pakistan by 111 runs.

Pick of the week's correspondence

Mandelson's memory

To The Times

I find it remarkable that a senior politician cannot recall being engaged in conversation with a young woman in a dressing gown while wearing only a T-shirt and Y-fronts. Yet when it comes to publishing a memoir, every detail of their time in government can be recalled with great clarity.
Tom Moore, Jesmond, Newcastle upon Tyne

Leave it to the locality

To The Economist

My research supports your report about the chronic weakness of the British state. Mostly, things get to happen in Britain when central government is not involved. The impetus for change comes from outside the Whitehall machine, from philanthropists, land owners, charities, universities and, above all, from local government.

Who built Britain's motorways? Who coordinated the national cycle network? Who built all those public-sector houses in the 1950s and 1960s? Who built our reservoirs, parks, aqueducts and sewers? Who championed the idea for Milton Keynes, Britain's fastest-growing city? Who pushed for the Channel Tunnel rail link? The answer is the same in every case and more: local government.

But local government these days is an emaciated shadow of its former self, hard hit by austerity, the loss of talented staff and low esteem. If Keir Starmer wants to get the government machine moving, a good part of the answer lies beyond his policy advisers, in regions and town halls.
Professor Ian Wray, Heseltine Institute for Public Policy, Practice and Place, University of Liverpool

AI's questionable gains

To the Financial Times

Delphine Strauss's article ("AI's impact on jobs is set to become more pronounced") mentions that workers are expected to take a hit before "productivity gains" from AI feed through.

How certain are those gains? Productivity is output relative to input. AI requires large investments in data centres, specialised chips and energy,

Exchange of the week

Saving the high street

To The Guardian

The decline of the high street predates austerity by decades ("Labour risks election wipeout unless it improves Britain's high streets, study finds"). If you encircle towns with retail parks that offer free parking, build houses between them and the bypass (which forces people into cars), and make parking in town centres difficult and expensive, you get urban dystopia, with a few shops that provide the things you can't buy online. Ipswich is a supreme example of this hollowing out.

The obvious answer is to turn empty shops and the buildings they occupy into housing, a change of use that councils perversely seem to resist. Housebuilders (and governments that cosy up to them) won't like it, of course, because they lose their economies of scale.

The solution is simple: penalise landlords who leave shops empty, and provide incentives for them and for developers to create the homes (and then customers) that we need.
Jeremy Walker, Leiston, Suffolk

To The Guardian

High streets have been changing throughout my lifetime (I'm 82 and had a high-street business for more than 20 years), and they have somehow survived with precious little government help. In my postwar rural Essex village, we had butchers, newsagents, bakers, ironmongers and three general stores (one a dairy), plus a haberdashery, hair stylists, sweet shops and an electrical shop with every plug and wire known to man.

There was consternation when the dairy went self-service, but soon everyone was shopping with a basket. Then came the grocery chains – the butchers and bakers disappeared, and the haberdashery closed. But the village adjusted and other enterprises appeared. The next watershed was out-of-town shopping, which pulled that rug away.

Track your lifetime and see where you were when the changes happened. Then ask yourself one simple question: "Did I support my local high street by using its shops, or did I blithely go to a superstore or online, yet still expect my local traders to be there when I occasionally went into town?" You can't subsidise every business because people choose to go elsewhere. Do we want to shop and drink locally or not? Please spare the wringing hands and the blame game about this government. If you want a high street, shop there!

Michael Newman, Shefford, Bedfordshire

plus constant human oversight. These are real costs that consume scarce resources with alternative uses. For example, as the FT reported this month, smartphone and PC prices are set to rise as the AI boom drains scarce memory chips.

The question is whether AI's output justifies these inputs. The productivity paradox of the 1980s and 1990s showed that technologies can yield negligible gains for extended periods. Moreover, task-level efficiency can mask system-level waste. The result is work redesigned rather than reduced.

The costs are immediate and measurable. The gains remain less certain. We may be mistaking motion for progress.
Swaibah Bilal, London

Defra's one-way thinking

To The Daily Telegraph

Defra wants to make the English countryside a less "white environment". According to the 2021 Census, about 81% of people in England and Wales identify as white, dropping to 53.8% in London and 48.6% in Birmingham. Does the Government therefore have plans to make our two largest cities more white through outreach schemes, or is the direction only one way?

Phil Angell, Helston, Cornwall

A vote against the dodo

To The Guardian

Ending the pristine state of the Chagos region is arguably a greater loss of biodiversity than

the extinction of the dodo, yet is often neglected in discussions of the transfer to Mauritius. No other large tropical ecosystem on Earth has been so well protected, and its value to the science of ecology is correspondingly immense.

It is not species richness or abundance that singles the region out: it is the ecosystem's near-natural functioning. Mauritian plans for fishing and other exploitation are not compatible with protection of the last great tropical wilderness area – which is currently teaching us how to repair and protect others.

If politicians could vote to save the dodo, one hopes they would. Yet watching them voting for a legacy of irreversible destruction means any future claims they make regarding biodiversity conservation will ring as hollow as a dodo's bones.
Clive Hambler, lecturer in biological and human sciences, University of Oxford

I ain't afraid of no ghost

To The Times

I read with interest your article on the NHS sending in an exorcist to rid a hospice of a "girl in red". It is not unusual for apparitions to appear in care settings – we had one or two in our care homes in Teignmouth. One night, staff refused to cross the courtyard as an apparition was taking a stroll across the garden.

Being a bossy, old-fashioned matron type, I reassured them that I would have a word with the apparition. This I did, and sure enough he disappeared. I am available for hire.

Christina Sell, managing director, Arbour Companions and Care, Bagshot, Surrey



"Are you wearing clean underwear? You never know when you might be photographed in one of Epstein's properties"

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Review of reviews: Books

Book of the week

A Shellshocked Nation: Britain Between the Wars

by Alwyn Turner

Profile 384pp £25

The Week Bookshop £21.99 (incl. p&p)

Alwyn Turner specialises in “bottom-up history – or, to be more precise, middle-up history”, said Robbie Millen in *The Times*. In his series of books on 20th century Britain, his focus has been not so much on high politics as on “the ordinary, suburban and middlebrow”.

In the latest, Turner sets out to “take the temperature” of the nation in the 20 years after the First World War. While he doesn’t ignore big events – the General Strike, the abdication crisis, the rise of the blackshirts (pictured) – what preoccupies him is the “stuff of daily life”: what people were buying, what they were reading, “what entertained them on stage or in the flicks”. And so we learn about the radio-fuelled craze for “outrageous new dances” – the shag, the shimmy, the Suzie Q – and the era’s new consumer goods: “the Aga cooker, the Anglepoise lamp, the Goblin Teasmade”. We learn about the craze for “pot-boiling crime thrillers”, and for the “low-key adventures of Rupert the Bear”. Turner’s account is “witty and wide-ranging”, and – refreshingly – he doesn’t scold his subjects for “not passing 21st century morality tests”.



We think of the interwar years as a far-off era, “cosier and more patriotic” than our own, said Andrew Marr in *The New Statesman*. Yet, as Turner shows, there are striking parallels between the two periods. The 1920s was a time of political turmoil, with the two-party system breaking down, as “attention-grabbing challengers” came from Left and Right”, and “constant criticism of the second-rate, wooden-tongued national leaders in No. 10”. The “unruly new media” were lambasted for spreading lies and half-truths, and even today’s trans debate was foreshadowed by the “media outrage over androgynous haircuts and dress codes”.

Building his account from newspapers and magazines, Turner has produced a typically “sharp and often surprising read”.

While the 1920s was a decade of stagnation, as Britain struggled to recover from the First World War, by the early 1930s the economy was “on an upswing”, said Jane Shaw in the FT. Some 2.5 million houses were built during this decade, and there was a motoring boom, fuelled by the arrival of “cheaper cars, like the Austin Seven”. Britain became more “mobile and more connected, and one result was cheap holidays: Billy Butlin opened his first holiday camp in 1936”. I wish I’d had a history teacher like Turner, said Juliet Nicolson in *The Spectator*. With his “gift for wit and tenderness”, he makes the past feel knowable. “This is history at its most fun, immersive, human and revelatory.”

Custody

by Lara Feigel

William Collins 432pp £25

The Week Bookshop £21.99 (incl. p&p)

When the academic and writer Lara Feigel lost a battle with her ex-husband over custody of their son, “what shocked her more than the verdict were the arguments used against her in court”, said Sophie McBain in *The Observer*. An article she’d written exploring “maternal ambivalence” was read aloud by the opposition barrister. She was criticised, she says, for “being too wilful, for writing books, for owning property”. To distract herself, she began to read obsessively about custody battles of the past, and this book is the result. Feigel’s first subject is the “extraordinary” Caroline Norton, who, in the early Victorian era, transmuted the pain of having her children taken away from her into “courageous campaigning”, said Natasha Walter in *The Guardian*. Her efforts led to women winning “basic rights over their own property and children”. From there, Feigel moves to an assortment of other cases, ranging from the French writer George Sand, who was forced to leave her two children behind when she fled an abusive husband, to the pop star Britney Spears (pictured), who in 2008 was “incarcerated in a psychiatric hospital without her beloved children”. It soon becomes depressingly clear that “there is little, if any, sense of forward movement to be found in these stories”.



That point is rammed home by Feigel’s final chapter, in which she “sets out to reveal what goes on in today’s family courts”, said Kathryn Hughes in *The Sunday Times*. Her investigations challenge the “easy assumption that mothers automatically get custody in these enlightened times”. The frequent ability of men to outspend their former wives on “better barristers, better expert witnesses and better nursery schools” often tips judgments in their favour. Charting a mostly “enraging history”, this is a “great roar of a book”.

Novel of the week

Glyph

by Ali Smith

Hamish Hamilton 288pp £20

The Week Bookshop £17.99

Ali Smith is a “cult figure” who is also “widely popular”, said John Self in *The Times*. That may be because, while her novels are experimental, they’re also “comforting”: they engage with the here and now, and are “made from human connections”. Smith’s latest novel, *Glyph* – a companion to last year’s *Gliff* – is narrated by two sisters, Patch and Petra, who were once close but are now estranged. The “hard to summarise” plot jumps between past and present, and as in *Gliff*, it involves a horse – in this case a “blinded war horse” rescued by the sisters’ great-grandfather during the First World War.

As ever with Smith, the “primary power” of this novel comes from its excavation of the “sediments of language”, said Keiran Goddard in *The Guardian*. Smith is famously fond of puns, but places them in the service of serious ends – such as expressing outrage at “genocide in Palestine”. This novel’s purpose, if it has one, seems to be to “make the reader nod in righteous disapproval”, said Francesca Peacock in *The Spectator*. With its “flat” characters and “tired” wordplay, I found it a truly feeble effort.

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 Opening times: Monday to Saturday 9am-5.30pm and Sunday 10am-4pm

Musical: American Psycho

Almeida Theatre, London N1 (020-7359 4404). Until 14 March Running time: 2hrs 50mins ★★★★★

During Rupert Goold's "gilded" 13-year tenure at the Almeida Theatre, in north London, it has staged 72 shows, 14 of which have transferred to the West End, and 11 to Broadway. In that time, the powerhouse venue has also bagged 21 Oliviers, said Dominic Cavendish in *The Daily Telegraph*, for plays including Mike Bartlett's verse-drama *King Charles III* and James Graham's *Ink*. It is quite a legacy for Goold – the "most exciting director of his generation" – who is now heading south of the river to take over at the Old Vic.



This adaptation is full of "demonic razzle dazzle"

For his swansong in Islington, said Arifa Akbar in *The Guardian*, Goold has restaged his debut production: an all-singing, all-dancing musical adaptation of *American Psycho*, Bret Easton Ellis's 1991 novel about a murderous Wall Street banker. In a typically slick, visually thrilling evening, the dark satire is "amped to ten" as it "sends up" 1980s yuppie culture. But the show "never spirals into kitsch, and our contemporary world of toxic masculinity, Trumpian capitalism and Insta-fuelled solipsism slowly, chillingly, creeps out of it". Arty Froushan impresses as Patrick Bateman, the preppy boy-next-door who "turns gradually lunatic" (while being a lot less sinister than Christian Bale in the film version). Duncan Sheik's score consists of "one great electro-synth number after another", and there's a "razor-sharp book"

by Roberto Aguirre-Sacasa. The "catwalk-style stage" works brilliantly, said Alex Wood on *What's on Stage*, especially for "dance-heavy moments". Combined with imaginative use of video projections and often "garishly overwrought" lighting, like a "nightmarish 1980s music video", the effect is "hypnotic".

For all the "demonic razzle dazzle", *American Psycho* is a "deadpan show with a downbeat story that sometimes feels in conflict with the maximalist nature of musical theatre", said Andrzej Lukowski

on *Time Out*. I am not sure it was really worth reviving, said Clive Davis in *The Times*. Sure, this production is slick and polished, but it hasn't a lot to say. Watching it is "an oddly bloodless exercise in nostalgia, like being forced to sit through a re-run of *9½ Weeks*".

The week's other opening

The Tempest Sam Wanamaker Playhouse, London SE1 (020-7401 9919). Until 12 April

"Some spells are cast" by this experimental *Tempest*, directed by Tim Crouch, who also stars as Prospero. But its high-concept, meta-theatrical trickery becomes wearying, and may also be "bamboozling" for those who don't know the play (*Guardian*).

Podcasts... on turmoil in America, Russia and Iran

During the first Trump administration, when liberal commentators warned that America was "descending into a fascist police state and the president was probably about to start bombing Canada", you could believe that they were suffering from "Trump Derangement Syndrome", said James Marriott in *The Times*. Today, you feel the condition should be renamed as "Accurate Perception of Reality Syndrome". As such, the new series of Anne Applebaum's **Autocracy in America** could scarcely be more timely; nor its first episode – about the Immigration and Customs Enforcement agency (ICE) – more topical. We hear from George Retes, a US military veteran who was driving to work when he was dragged from his car by ICE agents and held for three days with "no phone call, no lawyer, no shower, no nothing". Legal expert Liza Goitein argues that "we're moving towards a status quo in which the cities of this country really feel like police states". Ten years ago, I'd have thought: "Come off it. Not in America. Not in the 21st century. Well, now it all sounds frighteningly plausible."

In September 1999, more than 300 people were killed when bombs exploded in four apartment blocks in the Russian cities of Buynaksk, Moscow and Volgogradsk. The Kremlin narrative was that Chechen terrorists were behind the attacks, said



The Iranian royal family circa 1954

Rachel Cunliffe in *The New Statesman*, and the aftermath helped turn the prime minister – then a relatively unknown former FSB chief – into a "national hero". He became president not long after. But then a fifth bomb was discovered before it detonated. And investigative journalists found that the trail led back not to Chechnya, but to the FSB itself. Conspiracy theory? Or sickening truth? A new Radio 4 seven-part series, **The History Bureau: Putin and the Apartment Bombs**, digs into "one of the most contested stories in modern Russian history". The first episode gets off to a slow, expository, start, said Miranda Sawyer in *The Observer*. But then Vladimir Putin arrives, and "as he tightens his grip on power", this series, presented by Helena Merriman, "tightens its grip on the listener".

Want a clearer idea of what is going on in Iran? For the long view, said Patricia Nicol in *The Sunday Times*, seek out **Empire: World History**, which over 25 episodes (beginning with No. 96) offers a panoramic survey from antiquity to the present day. For the 1979 revolution and its aftermath, listen to a "riveting" new four-part special, **Revolution in Iran**, from *The Rest Is History* duo. And for "insightful" analysis of the current situation, turn to **The Rest Is Classified** – a series that launched with an episode on the ousting of the elected PM in 1951 to protect US and British oil interests.

Stars reflect the overall quality of reviews and our own independent assessment (5 stars=don't miss; 1 star=don't bother)



Is This Thing On?

2hrs 1min (15)

Likeable comedy based on the life of British comedian John Bishop

★★★

The first two films made by the actor-turned-director Bradley Cooper – *A Star Is Born* and *Maestro* – were rich in “showy pizzazz and ostentatious directorial flourishes”, said Wendy Ide in *The Observer*. By contrast, his latest, which is loosely based on the life of the British comedian John Bishop, is “refreshingly informal and intimate”. With the story relocated to New York, it stars Will Arnett (*Arrested Development*) as Alex, a “slightly crumpled middle-aged man” whose marriage is running out of steam. He stumbles into comedy when he goes to a West Village bar and signs up to an open-mic night as a way of avoiding the \$15 cover charge. After a couple of minutes on stage, he draws “a few laughs” from his audience – which is enough to spur him on to do more. Arnett, whose voice alone “speaks of two-day stubble, cigarettes and disappointment”, is excellent, as is Laura Dern as his wife; and Cooper pops up too in a “scene-stealing” role as Will’s best friend. Alex’s comedy isn’t “based on jokes”, it is “rambling, dislocated and droll”, and the film’s screenplay (by Cooper) “takes the same approach”. The result is “unassuming, amiable storytelling that sneaks up on you”.

This is a “likeable and spirited” movie featuring a typically “committed” central performance by Arnett, said Peter Bradshaw in *The Guardian*. But I did find myself wondering: shouldn’t a film about comedy be, well, funny? It struck me as “perfectly watchable”, said Matthew Bond in *The Mail on Sunday*, but the dialogue is annoyingly “mumbled” and the camera work “wobbly”. Overall, *Is This Thing On?* is “very slight and a tad slow too. The result is not quite comedy but not quite drama either, and while you’ll leave undeniably heart-warmed, you’ll also feel slightly short-changed.”



Nouvelle Vague

1hr 46mins (12A)

Richard Linklater’s homage to the French New Wave

★★★

Films about films can alienate the “non-cinephile viewer”, said Kevin Maher in *The Times*. But happily, Richard Linklater’s “visually lush and frankly encyclopaedic account” of the making of Jean-Luc Godard’s *Breathless* (*À bout de souffle*) doesn’t depend on the viewer picking up on every reference: its “fundamental beauty” lies in “the lightness and the love that Linklater brings to the material”. Set over the course of *Breathless*’s 23-day shoot in the summer of 1959, *Nouvelle Vague* is focused on the “tense” relationship between Godard (Guillaume Marbeck) and his producer Georges de Beauregard. It also examines “the sweetly unfolding relationship between the leads”, Jean Seberg (Zoey Deutch) and Jean-Paul Belmondo (Aubrey Dullin). It all builds into “a film of great passion” that is “full of unexpected tenderness” – and which shouldn’t only appeal to aficionados.

“Linklater certainly recreates the look, feel and sound” of Godard’s masterpiece, said Deborah Ross in *The Spectator*: as in *Breathless*, the dialogue is almost entirely in French; it is shot in black and white; and many New Wave innovations are on show, such as natural light, handheld cameras and choppy cutting. But while *Nouvelle Vague* is “intelligent and funny” and rather fascinating, it is also “far too celebratory to be revelatory”: Godard remains an enigma, and it fails to examine the old-school misogyny on display in his film and others like it. Still, the impact of the French New Wave is hard to overstate, said Robbie Collin in *The Daily Telegraph*. And it seemed to me that this homage could have done with more of the movement’s “reactive, incautious, free-range” approach. Instead, “its light touch starts to feel uncomfortably like a lack of substance”.



Shelter

1hr 47mins (15)

Jason Statham is back, but this time he’s in a cardie

★★★

In Jason Statham’s last two films, *A Working Man* and *The Beekeeper*, “he played a special forces veteran trying to keep a low profile as, respectively, a construction-site foreman and, yes, a beekeeper”, said Brian Viner in the *Daily Mail*. In *Shelter*, Statham sticks to the formula by playing Michael, a special forces veteran who lives in a disused lighthouse on a remote Scottish island. His quiet existence is turned on its head, however, when he rescues a girl (*Hamnet*’s Bodhi Rae Breathnach) from storm-tossed waters near his home. Duly lumbered, in the “time-honoured way of cinematic tough guys”, with an unwanted companion, Michael must then deal with various rogue MI6 agents who are sent to kill him. With his voice never rising “above a gruff whisper”, he spends the rest of the film dispatching baddies while toggled-up in fetching knitwear.

“If you ever felt Jason Bourne could be improved by an English accent and less hair, *Shelter* is the movie for you,” said Danny Leigh in the *Financial Times*. Statham and Breathnach “make an oddly watchable mismatch”, and all “the aggro is well choreographed and slightly mad”. “Few things in life are as reliable” as an action-thriller led by “the Stath”, said Helen O’Hara in *Empire*. But I must say, I found this one rather soul-sapping. The script “continually swerves human reactions in favour of tough-guy lines”, and the whole thing “feels recycled from a hundred other films”. Sure, it’s “pleasantly incongruous” watching Statham “taking henchmen apart” while wearing a cardigan, but “the formula could have used a little more juice”.

Wonder Man: a Marvel series that hasn’t much to do with superheroes

“We are back in the Marvel Cinematic Universe (MCU). If you feel fatigue stealing over you already, banish it!” said Lucy Mangan in *The Guardian*. This nifty and unexpectedly excellent eight-part series on Disney+ follows Simon, an actor with secret superpowers (Yahya Abdul-Mateen II) who has been trying to make it in Hollywood for years. Then he gets a shot at auditioning for a film about his childhood hero, Wonder Man. As a result, he meets Trevor Slattery (Ben Kingsley), “a washed-up, drug-addled actor” – who is a character that first appeared in *Iron Man 3*. Slattery has a sinister purpose in taking Simon under his wing, and there are some superheroics to please MCU fans. But “the real meat of the thing” is the “meticulous and moving examination of the growing friendship



Kingsley and Abdul-Mateen

between the men”. The series also serves as “a meditation on the film industry and a masterclass on the art of acting”.

The show “has a distinctive sense of wonder”, said Mike Hale in *The New York Times*. Yet the low-key buddy comedy sometimes feels at odds with the series’s Marvel wrappings. “The more realistically human you make your characters and their interactions, the more obtrusive and artificial the mandatory superhero material will seem.” I’d call it a “rare morsel of actual substance”

in a cinematic universe “gone thoroughly to seed”, said Louis Chilton in *The Independent*. But it’s unlikely that this breezy departure from the usual bilge will do much “in the long term for a franchise whose rattling breaths are numbered”.

Exhibition of the week **Nan Goldin: The Ballad of Sexual Dependency**

Gagosian, 17-19 Davies Street, London W1 (020-7493 3020, gagosian.com). Until 21 March

Forty years ago, the American photographer Nan Goldin published what became “one of the most influential photo books ever made”, said Jacqui Palumbo on CNN. Entitled *The Ballad of Sexual Dependency*, it documented life in New York City’s East Village in the 1970s and 1980s, with excursions to Chicago, London and Mexico City. The “searingly intimate” pictures showed Goldin and her “predominantly queer” friends in a variety of locations, from “darkened nightclubs” to “daylit bedrooms”. Their gazes are variously “bright, or disaffected, or longing”, and cigarette smoke hangs in the air. Goldin conceived the series “as a slideshow timed to songs by The Velvet Underground and Dionne Warwick”, which was played in nightclubs. The photos were rarely displayed together. Now, though, they have come to the UK for the first time, and are being shown as framed prints at the Gagosian gallery in Mayfair.

Goldin, who was born in 1953, “was a teenage runaway”, said India Block in *The London Standard*: after her beloved sister died by suicide, she fled the “stifling” Boston suburb she’d grown up in and moved to New York, where she threw herself into the city’s gritty underground scene. She originally started photographing her friends’ exploits when she discovered drinking (then heroin), “and wanted a record unaltered by mind-altering substances”. Named after a song by Bertolt Brecht, the *Ballad* series is “glamorous, engrossing and gross



Sandra in the mirror, NYC (1985): “emotional texture and atmosphere”

(in a good way)”: hyper-saturated images show a heavily pregnant woman in “a sparkly bikini”, a friend masturbating, someone else urinating, “a vulva framed by a surgery scar from an ectopic pregnancy”. Given the rawness of the images, “there’s something rather punk” about seeing them “gussied up and gorgeous” in a gallery; though you do long to see them “in a darkened room with pulsing music”. Still, “with each photograph occupying the same size frame”, your eye is left free to alight on whichever moment it chooses; and all these years on, the pictures are “as fresh, exciting, comforting and confronting” as they were in 1986.

“I’ve been familiar with these images for much of my adult life,” said Adrian Searle in *The Guardian*, and what struck me on this viewing was how “normal” the lives of Goldin and her friends look today. “We are now used” to people posting photos online as an often “self-conscious and calculated mirage of their lives”. Still, the great power of these photographs – each of which “leaves you on a kind of brink” – is undiminished, and the display here, which covers three black walls, is satisfyingly immersive, sending the eye “pinballing between captured moments and emotions”. The “apparent casualness” of Goldin’s approach is deceptive: there is an “emotional texture and atmosphere” to her work that proves that “not everyone who can hold a phone can take photographs worth looking at”.

Where to buy...

The Week reviews an exhibition in a private gallery

Grayson Perry

at Piano Nobile

It’s easy to knock Grayson Perry, and a lot of people do. The art world hates it when its members become successful in other disciplines, and since winning the Turner Prize in 2003, Perry (b.1960) has moonlighted in so many fields – broadcasting, writing, singing, even architecture – that it’s a wonder he has found the time to make any actual art. This shouldn’t, however, detract from his particular and often wildly weird graphic sensibility. This show – really more of a display – brings together a number of older Perry works, ranging from pastiches of medieval maps emblazoned with his personal iconography to a berserk woodcut depicting the artist in full-on Margaret Thatcher drag. There are some of his famous off-kilter ceramics, too,



Detail from Vote for Me! (2023), woodcut

notably a platter bearing an oppressive, Anselm Kiefer-esque image of a wintry field in Perry’s native Essex; and a lurid orange and green etching that features a likeness of Mark Zuckerberg beaming out over the outline of the North American continent. It’s a lot of fun. Prices on request.

96 & 129 Portland Road, London W11 (020-7229 1099). Until 27 March

An unfinished masterpiece?

A leading art historian has reignited a long-standing debate about George Stubbs’s *Whistlejacket*.

Famously, the life-size painting of the eponymous racehorse – commissioned by the animal’s owner, the Marquess of Rockingham, in 1762 – has a plain background. This makes it feel modern, Bendor Grosvenor told *The Times*, and “we want to believe that Stubbs was having a little experimentation”. But his research leads him to believe that Stubbs painted the horse first, and planned to return to include a landscape – but was stopped by his patron. This theory tallies with an anecdote from the time, in which the horse saw its unfinished portrait, and was so startled, it tried to attack it. The Marquess was supposedly pleased by its reaction, and declared the work complete. In March, *Whistlejacket* will be joined in the National Gallery by *Scrub*, another Stubbs horse portrait that is very similar to the former, except that it has a traditional background.



A guide to what's worth seeing and reading

Showing now

A last chance to catch **Lee Miller**, the largest retrospective of the American photographer's work ever staged in Britain, taking in everything from her participation in French surrealism to her war work. Ends 15 February, Tate Britain, London SW1 (tate.org.uk).

Laura Wade's acclaimed new version of **The Constant Wife**, Somerset Maugham's tale of adultery, is on a five-month tour with the RSC. Kara Tointon leads a "stylishly rearranged" production, which has an original jazz score by Jamie Cullum (Guardian). At the Oxford Playhouse until 7 February, then Richmond, Brighton and on. Ends 16 May (rsc.org.uk).

Book now

Novelists, politicians and historians are gathering for nine days of talks, debates and workshops at the **Oxford Literary Festival**. Yann Martel and Jung Chang will be discussing their new books, and Simon Schama the history of antisemitism. 21-29 March, various venues around Oxford (oxfordliteraryfestival.org).

The Britten Sinfonia are joined by the Tenebrae choir for **Seven Last Words from the Cross**, a Lenten concert. Barber's *Adagio* and Allegri's *Miserere* are followed by James MacMillan's *Seven Last Words*. 26 March, The Apex, Bury St Edmunds, Suffolk, then London and Snape Maltings, Suffolk (brittensinfonia.com).



The Constant Wife: on a five-month tour

Hollywood actor Chris Pine (*Star Trek*, *Wonder Woman*) will be heading to the UK this summer to star in a new version of Chekhov's **Ivanov**, written and directed by Simon Stone. 4 July-19 September, The Bridge Theatre, London SE1 (bridge theatre.co.uk).

Just out in paperback

The Ghosts of Rome by Joseph O'Connor (Vintage £9.99). The second volume in a planned trilogy based on the true story of the Vatican Escape Line. This "thrilling tale" of "priests, parachutes and Puccini" follows Monsignor Hugh O'Flaherty and his fellow conspirators as they help Allies escape Nazi-occupied Rome. "Jeopardy quivers through it" (Times).



Best books... Steven Isserlis

The celebrated cellist picks six neglected Victorian gems. His new album, 1851, explores some of the music written that year by a circle of musical friends. He performs with pianist Connie Shih, playing on an 1851 Erard piano (Hyperion £12.50)

The Four Sisters by Charles Dickens. It seems odd to refer to anything by Dickens as neglected, but few people seem to know this story of four indistinguishable sisters. It appeared in Dickens's first publication in book form, *Sketches by Boz*, 1836 (Penguin £12.99). Mad – and hilarious.

Erewhon by Samuel Butler, 1872 (Penguin £12.99). Erewhon (an anagram of nowhere) is a fictional land where illness is regarded as criminal, crime as an illness and machines are banned. Not Butler's greatest book, but astonishing in its prescience:

he predicts and satirises with striking accuracy huge swathes of our modern world – including the rise of AI.

The Fixed Period by Anthony Trollope, 1882 (University of Michigan Press £17.95). A memorable oddity from Trollope: the governor of another fictional land, Britannula, rules that to reduce the burden on the young and spare their elders the indignities of old age, citizens attaining the age of 66 will be taken to a place where their every whim will be indulged for a year – and then be humanely euthanised. Chillingly convincing.

The Law and the Lady by Wilkie Collins, 1875 (OUP £12.99). Many readers know Collins for *The Moonstone* and *The Woman in White*, but his other oft-criticised late books are well worth exploring – particularly this one. It features (perhaps) the first female literary detective, and several other extraordinary characters including Miserrimus Dexter, a legless maniac whose opening scene may be the strangest in all Victorian literature.

Hester by Margaret Oliphant, 1883 (OUP £9.99). I don't understand why this rich, involving tale is not better known. The wealthy, capable Catherine Vernon takes various relatives under her wing (including the eponymous Hester). Her generosity is mostly rewarded with comic ingratitude, brilliantly depicted. For me, this novel holds its own with the classics.

Television

Programmes

Betrayal David Eldridge's four-part spy thriller is about a mid-ranking MI5 officer who is told of an imminent threat to the UK. Sun 8 & Mon 9 Feb, ITV1 21:00 (60mins).

Lord of the Flies

Jack Thorne, who wrote *Adolescence*, has adapted William Golding's novel about schoolboys who turn feral after being stranded on a tropical island. Sun 8 Feb, BBC1 21:00 (60mins).

Panorama: Knife Crime – What Happened to Our Boys?

An investigation into the failings that led to two teenage boys being exploited by criminal gangs and, ultimately, murdered. Mon 9 Feb, BBC1 20:00 (60mins).

Small Prophets

Mackenzie Crook's new comedy series stars Pearce Quigley as a lonely twitcher, whose partner disappeared seven years ago. With Michael Palin. Mon 9 Feb, BBC2 22:00 (30 mins).

Films

The Woman King

(2022) Well-received historical drama starring Viola Davis as the leader of a band of female warriors in West Africa. Sat 7 Feb, C4 21:30 (160mins).

Charade (1963) Stylish suspense caper set in Paris, starring Cary Grant and Audrey Hepburn. Tue 10 Feb, Film4 16:35 (135mins).

Wuthering Heights (2011) As Emerald Fennell's version of Emily Brontë's novel hits the cinemas, here is a chance to revisit Andrea Arnold's radical retelling. Thu 12 Feb, Film4 23:10 (160mins).

New to streaming

Skyscraper Live Alex Honnold – the climber known for *Free Solo*, about his ascent of El Capitan – was filmed last month climbing a 508-metre skyscraper in Taiwan. This feat is on Netflix. *Free Solo* is currently on BBC iPlayer.

Take That "Unexpectedly revealing" three-part documentary about the rise, fall and resurrection of the 1990s boy band (Telegraph). On Netflix.

Titles in print are available from The Week Bookshop on 020-3176 3835. For out-of-print books visit biblio.co.uk

Owing to changes at the BBC, we are unfortunately no longer able to publish a summary of *The Archers*

Properties near spectacular coastal walks

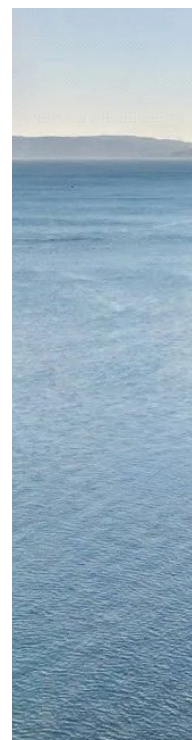


◀ **Isle of Wight:**

Padmore House, Whippingham. Fine 17th century house with an elegant Queen Anne facade, set in 15 acres close to the Isle of Wight Coastal Path. 7 beds, 4 baths, kitchen/breakfast room, 4 receps, garden, parking. £2.5m; Spence Willard (01983-200880).

▼ **Devon:**

Hope Cottage, Dartmouth. A charming waterside cottage with views over the River Dart and out to sea. 3 beds, 2 baths, kitchen, 2 receps, garage (by separate negotiation). £925,000; Knight Frank (01392-848842).



▲ **Northumberland:** The Byre, Fenham. This handsome stone house is set against the majestic backdrop of Lindisfarne Bay, with views across the tidal causeway to Holy Island and the Farne Islands. 3 suites, kitchen, 2 receps, outbuildings, garden, parking. £700,000; Finest Properties (0330-111 2266).



▲ **Cornwall:** Flanders House, Crackington Haven. Characterful house dating back to the 1600s on Cornwall's north coast. Set in mature gardens, including an orchard, and close to the beach. 4 beds, 2 baths, 4 receps, garden, workshop, garage. £975,000; Strutt & Parker (07502-609353).





◀ **Argyll and Bute:** Achnaba Town House, Achnaba. A duplex townhouse in a delightful position on Scotland's west coast, by Loch Fyne and overlooking Eilean Glas. 5 beds, 4 baths, kitchen, recep, communal garden and grounds, parking. £425,000; Galbraith (01786-434600).

▼ **Devon:** The Beacon, Exmouth. A duplex penthouse (red brick building) with views out to sea and along the seafront. Exmouth offers walks along the Jurassic Coast. Main suite, 2 further beds, shower, open-plan kitchen/dining room, recep, balcony, communal gardens. £625,000; Knight Frank (01392-848839).



▼ **Pembrokeshire:** The Hall, Angle. Splendid manor house with approx. ten acres of gardens and woodland running down to the coast. The scenic route from the pier is known locally as the Hall Walk. 7 beds, 5 baths, kitchen, 7 receps. £1.5m; Country Living (01437-616101).



◀ **Kent:** St Elmo, Deal. An impressive Grade II Georgian townhouse on the seafront, with views across the Channel to France. 4 beds, family bath, kitchen, 2 receps, garden, outbuilding. £975,000; Bright & Bright (01304-374071).

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Is reheated rice dangerous?

Many home cooks live in fear of “fried rice syndrome” – and so routinely throw out leftover rice, says Joe Zadeh on Vittles. A type of food poisoning, it is caused by *Bacillus cereus*, a microscopic organism that thrives in starchy foods, and causes horrible bouts of vomiting and diarrhoea, which in some cases can be fatal. Yet in many cultures, reheating rice is normal – and people from those places (anecdotally at least) aren’t always falling ill. So have the risks been exaggerated? Yes and no, says Prof Enzo Palombo, a microbiologist from Melbourne. What’s true is that *B. cereus* is unusually hardy; unlike most food-borne bacteria, it forms spores which can survive the cooking process. But this is where the confusion lies. Above 65°C, the spores are dormant; and the same is true at below 5°C (typically the highest temperature of a fridge). The risk lies when the spores are in the “danger zone” between 5°C and 65°C; if left in this range for long, the spores may produce toxins that will “muck up your guts”. In short, rice that has been kept in a cool fridge for a couple of days, and then thoroughly reheated, should be “fine”, but steer well clear of rice (or pasta, for that matter) that has sat at room temperature for any length of time.

The rotisserie chicken boom

It may be a bad time for restaurants, but one type of establishment appears to be thriving, says Tomé Morrissey-Swan in The



Toum: rotisserie chicken in Mayfair

Daily Telegraph. In recent years, rotisserie chicken has “become a hit in the UK”. A “new wave” of restaurants has spread across the country, “dedicated to cooking birds on rotating skewers” – a method that “continuously bastes the bird in its own juices, resulting in more tender meat than a regular roast chicken”. At the recently opened Norbert’s, in east Dulwich in London, whole rotisserie chickens with “dark and gnarled” skin arrive on old-fashioned platters, along with potatoes basted in chicken fat. It joins the likes of Toum in Mayfair and the Knave of Clubs in Shoreditch. Meanwhile, “Manchester has The Trading Route and Tartuffe”, and in Leeds there’s The Empire Café. So why

is “France’s famous market food” proving popular here? A desire for simplicity “in uncertain times” may have something to do with it. And also the fact that “chicken offers lean protein”. Most pertinent, however, is price. At a time when the cost of dining out has rocketed, rotisserie chicken offers an affordable experience that still feels like a treat. At Norbert’s, for example, a meal with sides and drinks “rarely surpasses £30 a head – it’s hard to find better value in London today”.

How to make a carb-free risotto

If you fancy the luxuriousness of a risotto, but not the hefty hit of starch, then consider using cauliflower instead of rice, says Tom Hunt in The Guardian. It involves “ricing” a cauliflower – either by pulse-blending it or shaving it with a knife – so the “florets crumble into rice-like pieces”. You then proceed much as you normally would, albeit with a few alterations. Start by frying finely diced onion and celery in olive oil until translucent. Add some flaked almonds, followed by a whole riced cauliflower, and stir-fry for three minutes. Next add 300ml vegetable stock and 200ml of double cream; once this is boiling, reduce to a simmer and cook, stirring, “until the cauliflower absorbs all the liquid”. Then add grated cheese. For extra crunch, I add a topping made by frying the cauliflower leaves and fine slices of its stem in olive oil with some extra flaked almonds, until they’re “crisp and golden brown”.

Recipe of the week

This is one of my go-to easy meals for one, says Suzie Lee. Quick, delicious, spicy and lip-smacking, these noodles are made using ingredients from the cupboard, so it is super easy. I like to eat this with a crispy fried egg, some fried peanuts, spring onions and an extra drizzle of chilli oil.

Hot peanut butter noodles

Serves 1

100g nest of dried thick egg noodles 1 heaped tbsp peanut butter (crunchy or smooth)
1 tsp crispy chilli oil ½ tsp chicken or vegetable stock powder
1½ tsp rice vinegar (or more if you like it tangier) drizzle of sesame oil
To serve (optional): fried egg sliced spring onions

- Bring a saucepan of water to the boil and cook the noodles according to the packet instructions.
- In a serving bowl, combine the peanut butter, crispy chilli oil, stock powder and rice vinegar. Stir well to combine.
- Once the noodles are cooked, add 1-2



tablespoons of the hot noodle cooking water to the bowl and stir to create a sauce.

- Drain the noodles and add them to the bowl, then toss everything together until combined. Drizzle with sesame oil, then add any optional toppings and serve.

Taken from Simply Speedy Chinese by Suzie Lee, published by Quadrille at £24. Photography by Uyen Luu. To buy from The Week Bookshop for £21.99 (incl. p&p), call 020-3176 3835 or visit theweekbookshop.co.uk.

Beaujolais is back



“Fresh and bright” reds are in fashion once again, says Victoria Moore in The Daily Telegraph – which is good news for beaujolais. Once associated in British eyes primarily with “beaujolais nouveau” – a phenomenon that thankfully no longer inspires so much “hoopla” – the region now produces an array of “seriously good”, “lighter medium-bodied wines”, typically in the £15 to £28 spectrum. I love this style of red chilled, in the depths of winter, poured with a warming casserole such as coq au vin.

“Particularly good” is **Elisa Guerin La Vigne de Mon Père 2023 Moulin-à-Vent** (£18; The Wine Society): a wine of great virtuosity, it has “subtle notes of rose amid the usual redcurrants”. Also recommended is **Jean-Marc Burgaud Morgon Côte du Py 2023** (£25; Abingdon Fine Wine) – a “very precise and immaculate” wine from one of the region’s “superstar producers”. **Domaine de Vavril Cuvée de l’Ecluse 2024, Côte de Brouilly** (£16.85; Haynes Hanson & Clark) is “utterly charming”, with a “seductive ease and brightness”. Or try Sainsbury’s **Taste the Difference Château de Pierreux Brouilly 2023** (£17): it’s “really good to see wine of this quality under a supermarket own-label”.



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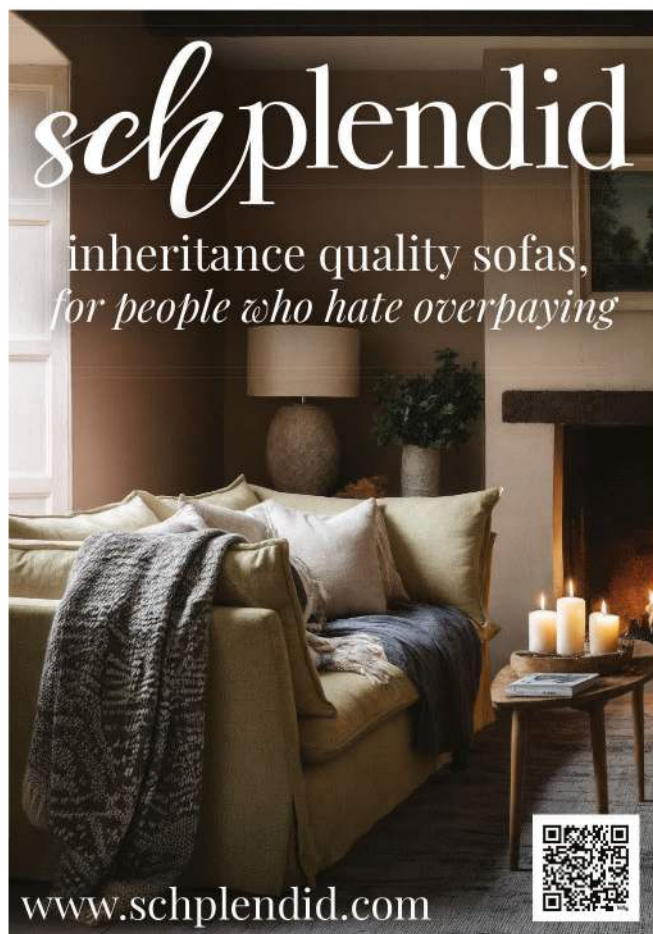
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New cars: what the critics say



Genesis GV60
from £54,115

Auto Express

This electric SUV has been around for a while, but its maker, Genesis, the luxury arm of Hyundai, has given it a midlife update. It now has a “cleaner, more modern look”, with new headlights and wheels, as well as a bigger battery that boosts the range of the base model by 27 miles. A 10%-80% charge takes just 18 minutes. “If you can bring yourself to try something new”, the GV60 could be most rewarding.

The Scotsman

“Fast and practical”, the GV60 is a joy to drive: it’s a “dawdle” on country lanes, and it “simply gobbles up the motorway miles. And ooooh... the silence.” There’s very little road noise, making the cabin “a lovely place to be”. The steering wheel has an interesting D shape and comes with some useful buttons built in. Still, this is by no means a cheap car, especially compared with its rivals.

What Car?

“A brilliant electric car”, the GV60 has a “luxurious interior” with top-quality, soft-touch materials and lots of kit. All models get a 27-inch screen for the driver’s display and infotainment system, which is intuitive and quick; there’s a rotary controller, and physical buttons too. The front seats are spacious, but the sloping roof reduces headroom in the back, and the 432-litre boot isn’t huge.

The best... new beauty buys

◀ **CeraVe Balancing Air Foam Cleanser**

This “clever, super-gentle” cleansing foam is suitable for all ages and skin types. It hydrates, controls oil and creates a protective barrier without leaving skin dry or tight. Be warned: you’ll need “to wrestle it from your teens’ and partner’s hands” (£14.50; boots.com).

▶ **Naked Sundays CabanaClear Water Gel Serum SPF50**

Designed to be worn under make-up or reapplied over it, this “super-light” clear gel serum SPF isn’t thick or sticky. It sinks

in within seconds and provides factor-50 protection. It’s free from silicone, too (from £26.40; uk.nakedsundays.com).



◀ **Geek & Gorgeous 101 C-Glow** This “powerful” serum contains 15% pure vitamin C “at a fraction of the cost you would pay for most other brands”. Use in the morning to protect from pollution, brighten your complexion and boost collagen production (£11.95; geekgorgeous.co.uk).

▶ **Charlotte Tilbury Airbrush Flawless Setting Spray Matte Blur**

This setting spray really does make your make-up last longer. It smooths and blurs, controlling oil and shine to give a “flattering velvety finish”, matte but not flat (£32; charlottetilbury.com).

▶ **The Ordinary Retinal 0.2% Emulsion**

A good retinoid formula is “essential at night”, and this is “one of the strongest you can get before stepping up to prescription skincare”. Retinal works faster than retinol, and is “basically the vitamin that speeds up skin cell turnover and collagen production”, evening skin tone (£15.20; theordinary.com).



SOURCE: THE TIMES

Tips of the week...
doing laundry in winter

- Don’t use too much detergent – excess suds can actually leave laundry dirtier. Avoid fabric softeners, as they can leave a waxy residue that builds up and makes detergent less effective. Instead, add half a cap of white vinegar to the drawer.
- Tumble dryers are convenient for big loads, but may cost a lot to run. A heat pump tumble dryer is pricier, but will save on your electricity bills in the long run.
- Add tennis balls or wool dryer balls to the drum to speed up drying and soften clothes. If you have a tumble dryer, don’t overload it (or your washing machine for that matter); and clean the filters regularly.
- Small households might be better off with a heated airer. Use a dehumidifier and a window vacuum to prevent damp. Leave room between the clothes for air to circulate, and use a cover on your heated airer.
- An ordinary clothes airer or a Sheila Maid will also work well with a fan and a dehumidifier in colder months.

SOURCE: THE TIMES

And for those who
have everything...

Launching in spring, the Infinite Machine P1 is the fastest 125cc-equivalent electric scooter in its class. With a 6kW motor and a 3.2kWh removable battery, it has a top speed of 65mph and a range of up to 62 miles. **£6,700; infinitemachine.eu**

SOURCE: FINANCIAL TIMES

Where to find... learning
holidays in Europe

Learn how to plan and create **abstract artwork** in **Andalusia** on this 7-night trip, with five days of painting *en plein air* and in the studio with a tutor. Meals and local excursions are included, and all abilities are welcome (from €1,950, 19-26 May; granadaculturalholidays.com).

The bestselling author Kate Mosse co-hosts workshops with her writer husband Greg at this **creative writing retreat** in **Crete**, where guests can stay in little cottages surrounding a pool (from £1,575 per couple, 11-18 Aug; simpsonstravel.com).

If you can swim 500m in a pool and want to make the transition to open water, why not try a **swim camp** in **Cyprus**? Swims start in the shallow waters of the bay, with technical coaching and video analysis too (from £1,350 for 5 nights in June; swimtrek.com). Make your own **mosaic** with mosaicist Ingi at her villa on the coast in **Turkey**. For up to three guests (from £1,199 for six nights, courses Apr to Oct; responsibletravel.com).

SOURCE: THE GUARDIAN

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This week's dream: touring the vineyards of southern Bolivia

Bolivia is not well known for its wines – but cutting deep into the arid plateau in the country's southwest are narrow fertile valleys where vineyards have flourished for centuries. This region must have made the first conquistadors feel quite “homesick”, says Stanley Stewart in Condé Nast Traveller, so strongly does it remind one of Andalusia. The main towns, Tarija and Tupiza, have “sleepy” old squares and a distinct air of the Wild West (indeed, Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid fled here in around 1906, and died near Tupiza “in a hail of bullets”). There are “atmospheric *estancias*” where you can stay, and beautiful wineries offering tours and tastings. Some also have good restaurants.

Among the oldest vineyards is San Pedro, founded in the 16th century. Its “gracious” whitewashed buildings are set around cobbled courtyards where bougainvillea tumbles and fountains trickle. Production is now focused on its famous singani, a white grape brandy that is the Bolivian national drink. Also wonderful



Tarija's fertile valley is home to beautiful wineries

is the Tierra Roja estate, which was founded in 2008 and supplies wines to Central, a Lima restaurant named the world's best in 2023. But it was San Francisco de la Horca that really captured my heart – there's something about the weathered old equipment there, and the “big Burgundy-style red” I drank in its courtyard garden, a “sylvan paradise” that was alive with birdsong.

While in Bolivia, I also visited Potosí, a city set beside the Cerro Rico, a mountain that provided vast amounts of silver to the Spanish empire. You can still enter its mines, where millions of men have died over the centuries. (For protection, people offer llama

blood, coca leaves and singani to El Tío – The Uncle – a demonic figurine with an erect phallus.) And I finished my journey at an “elegant” new lodge, Jirira, beside the Salar de Uyuni, a salt flat like “a vast and peaceful nothingness”, with shallow waters that mirror the local flamingos, the mountains and the stars. *The writer travelled with Dehouche (dehouche.com).*

Getting the flavour of...



Madaba's magnificent mosaics

Most tourists in Jordan head straight to the ancient city of Petra and the desert wilds of Wadi Rum. But there are other marvellous places to see – including the little city of Madaba (pictured), which is known for its “spectacular” Byzantine and Umayyad mosaics, says Libby Ryan in The Daily Telegraph. The most famous is the huge map set into the floor of the Greek Orthodox St George's Church. Dating from the sixth century, and extending about 80 square metres, it depicts the Holy Land in extraordinary detail. But there are other wonderful mosaics too, such as those portraying African animals in the church on nearby Mount Nebo, from which Moses is said to have surveyed the Promised Land. And the city itself is a “quiet” but pleasant place with an “exciting” restaurant scene.

Chamonix without the fuss

Set at the foot of Mont Blanc, Chamonix is among the world's “gnarliest” ski resorts –

a place where winter sports “pioneers” come to test their limits. But it's also great for a more relaxed winter break, says Gemma Bowes in The Times, as I discovered on a “girls’ (aka middle-aged women's) weekend”. We enjoyed guided snow-shoe walks and a visit to a farm where I milked a goat, an activity I found “unfathomably relaxing”. (I also met a donkey who was kept to scare off wolves, being bigger and noisier than a guard dog.) In the evenings, we hung out in the hot pools at the “huge” QC Terme spa, and went to an “uplifting” outdoor disco with Silent Sessions, wearing headphones to do breathwork exercises and dance our hearts out “in a silent starlit forest”.

A foodie break in Broadstairs

It has drawn less “hype” than Margate, its neighbour at Kent's eastern tip, but Broadstairs is “having a moment”, says Toby Skinner in The Observer, with the opening of several “tiny” but excellent new family-run restaurants. Perhaps my favourite is Bar Ingo, where a father-son team create “decadent” *pintxos* inspired by their shared love of the culinary culture in the northern Spanish town of San Sebastián. But also “changing things up” is Fifteen Square Metres, a “pink-walled” space with just six tables where former *MasterChef* finalist Tony Rodd produces tasty and imaginative small plates. And then there's Aster, a vegan place with eight seats and two nightly sittings; Twenty Seven Harbour Street (another “classic” small plates restaurant); and the Txoko Bar (continuing the local “San Sebastián love-in”). Stay if you can at Smiths, a townhouse with six “dark-walled mod-Georgian” rooms above a good coffee shop and breakfast joint.

Hotel of the week



Zannier Băi San Hô Dak Lak, Vietnam

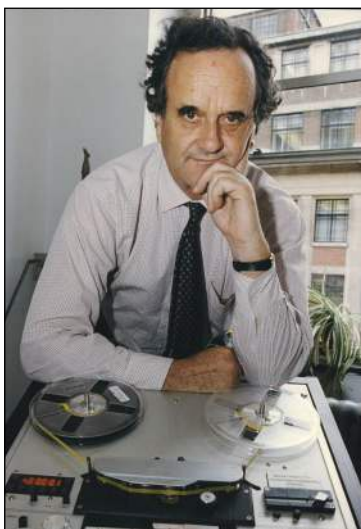
With elegant architecture inspired by the local vernacular, this resort is set beside an “empty” mile-long beach in a wonderfully remote corner of central Vietnam, says Rebecca Misner in Condé Nast Traveller. Surrounded by “verdant” hills and rice paddies, the 73 villas feature “earthy” tones and natural materials – wood, rattan, jute and bedding of “nubby” silk. The three restaurants are “excellent”, with breakfasts (including *bánh xèo*, or pancakes with shrimp, egg, herbs and fish sauce) that are “especially good”. And there's lots to do, including spa treatments, tennis and visits to local villages.

Doubles from £415; zannierhotels.com.

The BBC journalist known as “the Voice of India”

Mark Tully
1935-2026

When Rajiv Gandhi was told – while on a road trip deep into India’s interior – that his mother had been assassinated, he refused to believe it, until he had turned on his radio, and heard the news from Mark Tully of the BBC. Known as “the Voice of India”, Tully, who has died in New Delhi aged 90, was one of the most revered foreign correspondents of his generation, said *The Guardian*. He spent most of his life in India, and over the decades, won respect all over the country for his sensitive, knowledgeable broadcasts on key moments in the nation’s 20th century history – including the Bangladesh war of independence in 1971, the siege at the Golden Temple at Amritsar, the disaster at Bhopal and Indira Gandhi’s assassination, all in 1984, and Rajiv’s killing seven years later. There were times when his reporting enraged specific groups, said *The Daily Telegraph*, and during the Emergency of 1975-1977, Indira Gandhi had him expelled for more than a year; but in 2004, a poll found that 70% of Indians would be happy to have Tully as their prime minister.



Tully: planned to become a priest

song too much, and that my face was more appropriate in the pub than in the pulpit”.

After a few years working for a housing charity, he joined the BBC as an administrator in 1964, and was soon posted to Delhi. “Just after I arrived, sitting on the hotel verandah, I smelt the gardener’s food: it brought memories of my childhood flooding back. I suddenly sensed I had a root.” He started reporting, and in 1972 he was made bureau chief. He had, he said later, drifted into journalism. “It doesn’t obsess me. India is what obsesses me.”

A tall, rumped figure, he spoke in a plummy English accent but dressed in a *kurta*, smoked cheroots and was fluent in Hindi. His reports – rebroadcast in Hindi, Urdu, Tamil, Nepali and Bengali – often reached 50 million people in that pre-internet era, said *The Times*. He also wrote several books about India. His fans on the subcontinent called him Tully Sahib. “I owe everything to India,” he once said, “and if you asked me if I care more for England or India, I’d say India every time.”

Mark Tully was born in Calcutta in 1935, during the British Raj, where his father had a senior role at an Anglo-Indian company. His early childhood was spent in an exclusive neighbourhood known as Regent Park. The family had numerous Indian servants, but he had no Indian friends. His European nanny was under strict instructions that her charges did not “go native”. Nevertheless, said *The Daily Telegraph*, Tully saw ordinary Indian life unfold in the streets – and missed it after the family moved back to “dark, drab” England in 1945. He went to Marlborough College, then spent time in the Army before taking up a place at Cambridge, where he studied theology under Robert Runcie. He planned to train for the priesthood. But, he recalled, “the bishop told me I liked wine, women and

Tully sensationally left the BBC in 1994, having been enraged by its then-director-general, John Birt, whom he accused of “turning the BBC into a secretive monolith with poor ratings and a demoralised staff”. However, he returned soon after to front *Something Understood*, a long-running Radio 4 series that explored spirituality and philosophy. He had married Margaret Butler in 1960. They had four children and he lived with her on his prolonged visits to London each year. In Delhi, he shared his home with a fellow journalist, Gillian Wright. It was “complicated”, he said. “I am able to have a meaningful relationship with two women, but both women suffer.” He was knighted in 2002. He also received the Padma Shri (1992) and the Padma Bhushan (2005) from the government of India.

Mathematician whose work paved the way for GPS

Gladys West
1930-2026

Gladys West was an American mathematician who spent years in the postwar era making complex calculations about the forces that shape the Earth’s surface, using – among other things – some of the earliest IBM supercomputers, said *The New York Times*. The modelling she did for the US navy would go on to play a critical role in the development of GPS technology. Of course, she could not, at that time, have predicted the impact of her work; and she was almost 90 before her contribution was acknowledged.



West: walked three miles to school

Gladys Brown was born in rural Virginia in 1930, the daughter of impoverished sharecroppers. As a child, she realised that education offered the only possible escape from her parents’ hard life. So she walked three miles to her segregated, one-room school each morning, and won a full scholarship to Virginia State University. She completed a degree in maths; then, having saved some money by working as a teacher, she returned to study for a master’s. In 1956, she started work at the Naval Surface War Centre in Dahlgren, Virginia. There were just four black employees at the base at the time; one of them, Ira West, also a mathematician, became her husband. As government employees, they felt unable to take an active part in the civil rights movement; but they tried instead to challenge prejudice by showing that they were just as good as any white

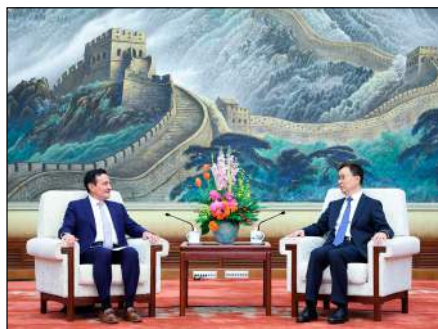
employee. “They hadn’t worked with us,” she explained. “They don’t know [black people] except to work in the homes and yards. So you got to show them who you really are. We tried to do our part by being a role model.”

In the early 1960s, she was one of the contributors to an acclaimed study that examined Pluto’s orbit relative to Neptune, a process that required five billion calculations. She then worked on satellite geodesy – using data from satellites to produce incredibly precise measurements of the Earth’s shape and orientation. This work, which involved creating complex algorithms for supercomputers the size of rooms, enabled the detailed mapping required for GPS. She eventually retired in 1998; two years later, aged 70, she was awarded a doctorate in public administration.

West’s work went unsung until 2017, when she wrote about her life for an event organised by a sorority she had joined at college. Tipped off by a fellow sorority member, a local paper invited her to be interviewed – and to her surprise, other papers picked up the article. Over the next three years, she was inducted into the Air Force Space and Missile Pioneers Hall of Fame, was named by the BBC as one of 100 influential and inspirational women, and became the first woman to receive the Prince Philip Medal from the Royal Academy of Engineering.

Companies in the news ...and how they were assessed

AstraZeneca: New York debut



In what was dubbed “the largest company transfer by market capitalisation in the history of the NYSE”, shares in British drugs giant AstraZeneca (AZ) began trading on the New York Stock Exchange this week. But as bosses hailed “the start of an exciting new period”, there was unease at home in the City, said the Daily Mail. Although the Anglo-Swedish firm, run by Pascal Soriot (far left), is maintaining listings in London and Stockholm, “the decision to put its US shares on an equal footing” has “raised fears” it will eventually switch its main

listing to Wall Street – a potentially “huge setback for London” since, at around £215bn, AZ is the largest constituent of the FTSE 100 by value. New York investors cheered the move, sending the stock 5% higher – and, on paper, it makes sense, said Henry Saker-Clark in *The Independent*. The cancer drug specialist makes “almost half its revenues in the US and is targeting further growth in the world’s largest drugs market”. Last year, AZ curried favour with President Trump by pledging \$50bn in US investment by 2030, while “rowing back on UK expansion”, said Julia Kollewe in *The Guardian*. But during Keir Starmer’s trip to China, Soriot promised another \$15bn to support its hubs there. It is relying on an \$18.5bn tie-up with China’s CSPC Pharmaceutical Group to spearhead a push into weight-loss and diabetes drugs, noted Elsa Ohlen on CNBC. Managing these potentially conflicting “geographic priorities” will require quite the “balancing act”.

Kraken: all it’s cracked up to be?

The potential loss of one of the FTSE 100’s star companies underscores the need for “new blood” on the London market, said Tracey Boles in *The Times*. Plenty of people, including in the Government, are hoping this will come in the form of a spinout from Octopus Energy, now the UK’s biggest supplier, which is planning to float its tech platform Kraken – recently valued at a “punchy” £6.25bn. Kraken’s clever tools include opening accounts and measuring smart meters. Often cited as Octopus’s secret weapon in poaching customers from British Gas, its software is now licensed to a host of other utilities, including EDF, E.ON and Severn Trent. “A many-tentacled approach may be needed to land this big beast.” London is vying with New York for the potential blockbuster float, and Octopus’s boss, Greg Jackson, has stressed the need to “hustle” for his custom. Ministers have duly taken a “golden share” worth £25m. Governments usually nationalise or invest either “to bail out failing firms whose collapse would be catastrophic” or “to fund projects that cannot otherwise attract capital”, said Kathryn Porter on *UnHerd*: Kraken fits neither category – though Octopus might be banking on the float’s proceeds to shore up its own capital position. Business Secretary Peter Kyle has denied the investment is a “bung”. Whatever the case, it will certainly increase scrutiny.

Starbucks: the coffee house of the future?

Starbucks shares shot up when Brian Niccol – who’d previously doubled revenues at Chipotle Mexican Grill – was named as its new boss in the summer of 2024. More than a year later, they are no higher, said Lex in the FT. “Yet under the surface”, the coffee chain is “gathering a head of steam”. After two years of declines, it has returned to quarterly sales growth. Niccol’s “Back to Starbucks” strategy has involved sprucing up stores to make them more comfortable, and adding staff to improve customer service. That has swelled costs, but at least he’s got the coffee flowing again. And he has other plans too, said Louisa Clarence-Smith in *The Times*, ranging from more customisable drinks, a new customer rewards scheme, and an espresso machine that will apparently cut the time it takes a barista to pull four espresso shots from 70 seconds to 35 seconds.

Barclay family: matriarch tapped

The implosion of the property, media and business empire built by Sir David and Sir Frederick Barclay has triggered “a string of legal battles involving the family”, said Luke Barr and Louis Goss in *The Daily Telegraph*. Now creditors are coming after the family matriarch. Deutsche Bank Luxembourg is pursuing Lady Reyna Barclay, Sir David’s widow, for £18.7m related to debts owed by her son Alistair Barclay – a former motor racing driver. In its petition to the High Court, Deutsche Bank claims that Lady Barclay had agreed to guarantee that two offshore trusts in Alistair’s name could cover the liabilities as they fell due, and that she is “independently wealthy” enough to honour that alleged commitment. Alistair’s lawyers argue that Lady Barclay offered nothing more than an unbinding “promise” – and so can’t be held legally liable. The case continues.

Seven days in the Square Mile

Precious metal prices rebounded after a historic sell-off – with much of the action, particularly in the **silver** market, influenced by febrile trading in China. The US Federal Reserve kept **interest rates** on hold within a 3.5% to 3.75% range, in defiance of President Trump’s wishes, after three cuts last year – citing “solid” growth and signs of stabilisation in the labour market. The Bank of England was predicted to follow suit and hold rates at 3.75% this week. The dollar rallied after Trump nominated Kevin Warsh as his pick to succeed Fed chair Jerome Powell. **Indian stocks** advanced after New Delhi agreed a trade deal with the US, lowering reciprocal tariffs from 50% to 18%. Both the **FTSE 100** and Japan’s **Nikkei 225** hit new record highs.

Shares in software, media and data companies globally suffered a punishing sell-off after AI giant **Anthropic** released a productivity tool for legal work, sparking fears that AI could eat away at core parts of their business. Among the biggest fallers in London were **Relx**, **Sage Group**, **Experian** and the **London Stock Exchange Group**. Advertising groups **WPP** and France’s **Publicis** also came under pressure.

Walmart became the first retailer to achieve a \$1trn valuation. **Disney** appointed the head of its theme-park division, Josh D’Amaro, to succeed Bob Iger as CEO. **Capgemini**, the French tech giant, said it will sell its US subsidiary owing to its contract with ICE. HMRC reported that an estimated one million Britons missed the deadline to file their **tax return** and now face penalties.

Murky deal

Could an end finally be in sight to the saga of Thames Water? Reports suggest that a new £16bn rescue deal with creditors has been hammered out, said Alex Brummer in the Daily Mail. Under the terms, they’d take a 30% cut to Thames’s £22.8bn debt pile in exchange for 10% of the equity, and have also pledged £3.15bn of new cash. The negotiations, with sharpshooters including Elliott, Silver Point and Pimco, have been conducted behind closed doors and much of the detail is obscure. That doesn’t bode well. Nor does “the lack of commitment by the creditors beyond 2030”. It will take longer than that to turn around this “notoriously leaky tanker”.

Issue of the week: Musk's starry mega-merger

Elon Musk is promising investors a rocket trip to the future – and a sprawling conglomerate to boot

Elon Musk pulled off one of the most audacious deals of his career this week – merging his rocket company SpaceX, with his loss-making artificial intelligence startup xAI. Fittingly for the world's richest man, said the FT, he has created “the most valuable private company in history”. Musk's supporters see the \$1.25trn mega-merger as further evidence of his “genius”: the stated aim is to launch a constellation of data centres into space to tap the unlimited, free energy of the Sun, and settle the problem of how to fuel the AI revolution for good. Critics, however, view the move as the entrepreneur's “latest example of financial engineering”. The merger will precede an IPO in June, billed as “the largest flotation of all time” – the date is reportedly important to Musk “because of a rare alignment of planets Jupiter, Venus and Mercury”. But the rapid timeline may have less to do with “celestial conjugations” than with Musk's desire to beat rival AI startups OpenAI and Anthropic to market and gain first-mover advantage with investors.

Given the numerous engineering challenges, “it sounds like the stuff of science fiction”, said The Economist – and, for a while it may remain just that. It is unclear, for example, whether the hardware needed can survive being repeatedly exposed to cosmic



“Ad astra”: a SpaceX rocket at Kennedy Space Centre

rays. Then there is the matter of cost. Although SpaceX is able to launch things into space for far less than any competitor, it's still not cheap. The commercial rationale for stitching the parts together, then, is shaky. A better reason might be financial. Musk's xAI is “a cash incinerator”, reportedly burning through \$1bn a month and still weighed down by the remaining \$12bn of debt from Musk's 2022 acquisition of Twitter. SpaceX, which reportedly generated profits of \$8bn last year, might be a handy cash cow. Last week, Musk's carmaker, Tesla, declared it had also invested \$2bn in xAI, raising further questions about his commitment to the company. The suspicion, said Andrew Orlowski in The Daily Telegraph, is that Musk's obsession with AI and robotics could see the carmaker “wither and die”. Some have speculated that it too could be folded into his new enterprise.

Plenty of people have bet against Musk before and lost. But for SpaceX's minority shareholders, this all-share transaction must look less like a visionary attempt to “accelerate humanity's future” and more like a sting carried out “with minimal scrutiny of valuation or a meaningful attempt to seek their views”, said Nils Pratley in The Guardian. “Ad astra!” cries Musk. Shareholders could be forgiven for taking a rather “less stellar” view.

Precious metals plunge: what the experts say

● Historic crash

For weeks, traders across the metals world have been glued to their screens, said Bloomberg, as prices for everything from gold to copper to tin – spurred to a record high “on a wave of hot money” – seemed “to break free from gravity”. Then, in just a few hours, the rally reversed “into one of the most dramatic crashes ever seen in commodity markets”. Silver's 26% plunge last Friday was “the biggest since 1980”; gold's 9% fall marked its worst day in decades. The trigger for the crash, which extended into Monday, was the nomination of Kevin Warsh to lead the US Fed. But in any case, after “weeks of relentless surges”, a correction in the overstretched metals market was long overdue. “Still, the speed and scale of the drop was breathtaking.” When gold – the asset of last resort – starts overtaking bitcoin on volatility measures, you know something's up.

● Meme metals

Analysts had been warning of a sudden reversal for months, said The New York Times. “Silver is always a death-trap,” said Rhona O'Connell, an analyst at StoneX. But the stakes were driven higher by an influx of retail investors, who poured \$1bn



Gold: as volatile as bitcoin?

into silver-focused index funds in January, sending the price up to \$120 an ounce, compared with \$30 a year ago. The boom-and-bust price action has drawn comparisons to the “meme stock” craze during the Covid-19 pandemic, said the FT – with individual traders left “on the

sharp end of the crash”. The tumult sparked “pandemonium” in New York's diamond district, where panic-selling set in.

● Buying the dip

Despite the turmoil, plenty of analysts stuck to their guns, said The Times. “Does the correction portend a durable shift,” asked Deutsche Bank's Michael Hsueh in a note. “We believe the answer is ‘no.’” Given continuing geopolitical and monetary uncertainty, he sees no evidence that central banks, institutions or retail investors have soured on precious metals and has reiterated the bank's target for gold of \$6,000/oz. “Buy the dip,” urged analysts at Jefferies. It seems plenty of investors were willing to do just that. Gold and silver both staged “a dramatic comeback” this week, with the yellow metal rising back above \$5,000/oz. Despite the falls, gold is still up by more than 60% over the past year.

Bot news

Adolescent angst Anthropic's CEO, Dario Amodei, has done the AI “equivalent of pulling the fire alarm”, said Danny Fortson in The Sunday Times. The gist of his new 19,000-word essay, *The Adolescence of Technology*, is that we still haven't awoken to an inevitable reckoning as ever-more intelligent systems test “who we are as a species”.

OpenClaw Leading the charge in that “step change”, said Aisha Down in The Guardian, is OpenClaw – a new viral “AI personal assistant” that promises to run your life with “almost no input”. Formerly known as Moltbot, it was launched in November by Austrian engineer Peter Steinberger. The possibilities are infinite: from texting “good morning” to your spouse to running your portfolio. Security experts are aghast: if hacked, agents such as OpenClaw “could be manipulated to target their users”. But so far, the bot is no great shakes as a trader, reports AI entrepreneur Kevin Xu, who instructed it to make \$1m. “It lost everything. But boy was it beautiful.”

Moltbook “OpenClaw appears unsettlingly capable of having its own life,” said Down. One creative offshoot is Moltbook – a social network developed exclusively for autonomous AI agents. “We're seeing a lot of really interesting autonomous behaviour in ... how the AIs are reacting to each other,” said Ben Yorke of AI vibe trading platform Starchild. Apparently, existential topics are very popular.

Eliminating a feudal housing arrangement...

Lex

Financial Times

“An Englishman’s home may well be his castle”, but the leasehold system – which affects about a fifth of homes, including the majority of flats in England and Wales – is “a crack in the edifice”, says Lex. So a government plan to tackle this “feudal-era arrangement”, in which leaseholders own a property for a set term but the underlying land belongs to a freeholder, is more than welcome. Yes, the PM’s decision to cap ground rent at £250 a year will “create losers”, the Church of England and fund manager M&G among them, but that’s no defence for this anachronistic system. In fact, the reform doesn’t go far enough. It also needs to tackle so-called “fleeceholds”, which allow freeholders and their estate managers to charge excessive sums to maintain common areas such as hallways and building exteriors. A 2024 review by the competition regulator found many homeowners “had no say over the company used, little recourse over substandard work” and “scant visibility” on costs. If Keir Starmer’s goal is to build more affordable houses, any real progress will be hard to make “until the market is sheared of these unhelpful distortions”.

...has set a dangerous precedent

Ben Houchen

The Daily Telegraph

For years, British politicians have “tested the patience of serious investors” by piling on taxes, slowing planning to a crawl, and talking “endlessly about growth while doing remarkably little to enable it”, writes the Conservative mayor of the Tees Valley. Yet one advantage has quietly kept capital flowing – the belief that Britain is still a country where the rules mean something, where contracts are honoured, “where the state can be trusted not to move the goalposts after the cheque has cleared”. The plan to cap ground rents on existing leasehold properties is a case study in how to squander that trust. Pension funds are already bracing for losses of about £30bn – money underpinning the retirement incomes of millions of British workers. And if the finances of freeholders are threatened, we can also expect more dilapidated and unsafe buildings. Ground rents are unpopular, and reforming the system for future developments is sensible. But a “dangerous principle” is now being established. Once a government has shown it is willing to “rewrite contracts when political pressure builds”, every future investor has to ask how safe their capital really is.

MbS: Saudi Arabia’s own Ozymandias?

Isabel Coles and Ruth Michaelson

The Observer

When the crown prince of Saudi Arabia, Mohammed bin Salman (MbS), drew up plans for Neom, a futuristic mega-project in the desert, local villagers were evicted at gunpoint “from a remote region the size of Albania” to make way for it. There were plans for “flying cars, giant robotic dinosaurs and a huge artificial moon” in this zero-carbon paradise, say Isabel Coles and Ruth Michaelson. The centrepiece was to be the Line: a linear city, comprised of parallel lines of “conjoined mirrored skyscrapers”, stretching 170km inland from the Red Sea. Neom was conceived as part of MbS’s Vision 2030 initiative “to wean the oil-rich kingdom off its dependence on crude”. Six years on, oil prices have fallen far below what Saudi needs “to balance its budget” and the estimated cost of Neom has ballooned as high as \$8.8trn. Other spending priorities, such as AI investment, now take precedence. MbS can’t afford to walk away entirely: Neom is an emblem not only for Vision 2030, but of his own rule. Bits of it will be built, but the mythical mega-city in the sands is likely to remain just that.

The unsexy king of the open road

Laurence Sleator

The Times

The Toyota Prius, so often the butt of car-enthusiast ridicule, has never been acclaimed for its sexy looks or va-va-voom, says Laurence Sleator. It goes from zero to 60mph... eventually, runs the old joke. But owners have had the last laugh. Experts at Auto Express have placed the Prius top of their list of the “50 modern cars that changed the world”, beating such icons as the Mini Cooper, Tesla Models S and 3 and Bugatti Veyron. It may look weird, but as the first mass-produced hybrid electric vehicle, the Prius has proved groundbreaking: it has forced the technology into the mainstream, seen off “VW’s attempt to fight back with diesel”, and pushed rival marques to follow suit. Hardcore motorheads may not be fans: the Prius “started the rot which now means all cars are just annoying appliances”, as Jeremy Clarkson put it. No car is for everyone, Toyota says. Yet since its release 30 years ago, it has sold millions of models across the world, with eco-conscious Hollywood A-listers, such as Tom Hanks, Leonardo DiCaprio and Cameron Diaz, among its buyers.

City profile

Kevin Warsh

“President Trump turned the search for a new Federal Reserve chair into a game show,” said Jonathan Levin on Bloomberg – declaring himself entirely satisfied with the winner. Kevin Warsh, he wrote on Truth Social, will be “one of the GREAT Fed Chairman (sic), maybe the best”. As one of the “two Kevins” deemed likely to take over when Jay Powell’s term ends in May, the nod was hardly out of the blue. Still, he is a curious choice. “Trump demanded a Fed dove” who’d deliver easier monetary policy – yet picked “a hawk”. No wonder Wall Street succumbed to an acute bout of “cognitive dissonance”. As traders piled into the dollar, gold and silver suffered their worst one-day crash since 1980.



Warsh, 55, cut his teeth at Morgan Stanley and became an economic adviser to George W. Bush, said The Times, before serving on the Fed’s governing board from 2006 to 2011. A decade-long stint with billionaire investor Stanley Druckenmiller has honed his market savvy. Fans admire Warsh’s “deep, long-held suspicion of quantitative easing”, said Robert Armstrong in the FT, but “critics see him as an opportunist who dispensed with his hard-money views when they became a barrier to professional ascent”. His rationale for cutting interest rates – that an AI-driven “productivity revolution” and a shrinking Fed balance sheet will keep inflation in check – is pure speculation. His “personal proximity” to Trump “won’t help with the optics”, said Bloomberg. Warsh’s father-in-law is Trump’s long-standing friend Ronald Lauder, the cosmetics heir said to have sparked the pursuit of Greenland.

Who's tipping what

The week's best shares

Crest Nicholson Holdings*Investors' Chronicle*

The housebuilder, which focuses on mid-premium homes in the South East, is benefitting from improved trading conditions. Profits are up 30%, aided by land sales, and debt is lower than guidance. Buy. 154p.

Kooth*Sharecast*

The mental health digital services provider has underperformed, due to worries over a US contract renewal and subdued UK growth. Canaccord has lowered its target to 330p, but expects a return to profit. Buy. 123.5p.

Luceco*Citywire*

The lighting specialist's EV charger sales have risen by 85% and profits are expected to beat forecasts. "Powered by its increasing exposure to energy transition", concludes Berenberg, which has raised the target to 175p. Buy. 148p.

Marston's*Citywire*

Christmas sales were flat for the pub/restaurant operator, which co-owns the Hobgoblin and Bombardier ale brands with Carlsberg. Still, Shore Capital believes deleveraging the balance sheet "brings the end game closer". Buy. 61p.

Renew Holdings*Citywire*

Shares in the infrastructure and essential engineering services firm are "materially undervalued", given a record order book, structural growth drivers and operating model flexibility, says Peel Hunt. Target £13. Buy. 943p.

Sage Group*The Times*

Cross-selling and up-selling have boosted the software provider's sales. Now shifting to a cloud-based subscription model. Shares are down on AI concerns, but the cheap valuation is attractive given historic returns. Buy. 995.4p.

Directors' dealings

Fintel

The fintech has been growing its support services arm with acquisitions – most recently, the £11m buyout of Pearson Ham's insurance pricing data business. Insiders, including CEO Matt Timmins and chair Phil Smith, have bought shares worth £855,628.

SOURCE: INVESTORS' CHRONICLE

...and some to hold, avoid or sell

Burberry Group*The Times*

The turnaround of the embattled fashion business may "finally be bearing fruit", amid surging Chinese sales. But profit recovery is priced in, shares are pricey and "self-help" can only go so far. Avoid. £11.70.

C&C Group*The Times*

Strong festive sales of Tennent's and Bulmers have boosted the drinks-maker and distributor's profits. But the scale of external headwinds has been exposed by a profit warning. Recovery prospects are for the patient and brave. Hold. 106.6p.

Card Factory*Citywire*

Peel Hunt has reiterated its 75p target on the card and gift retailer. Non-core activities are "interesting", and sales are steady ahead of Valentine's and Mother's Day. But after a weak Christmas, shares are "dead money for now". Hold. 68p.

Cranswick*Citywire*

Strong revenue growth and ongoing demand for premium pork and poultry products have boosted the food producer's profits. A "quality compounder" that is "bringing home the bacon", according to Berenberg. Hold. £52.70.

SThree*Investors' Chronicle*

The Stem recruiter has endured another "bruising year": profits have collapsed despite a return to growth in the US. A tech upgrade should drive higher margins in the long run, but is eating into "already shrunken profits". Hold. 197p.

Unite Group*The Times*

The student landlord's acquisition of Empiric gives exposure to the postgrad market. But foreign student numbers are down and Unite faces a cultural shift – students staying at home and attending local unis. Avoid. 572.5p.

Form guide

Shares tipped 12 weeks ago

Best tip**Netcall**

Investors' Chronicle
up 5.42% to 126.5p

Worst tip**Dunelm Group**

The Mail on Sunday
down 18.52% to 915p

Market view

"There are traps and opportunities everywhere – opportunities in risks, traps in opportunities. Investment is essentially a game of survival."

Bian Ximing, founder of Chinese trading firm Zhongcai, which netted \$500m from the silver rout. Quoted in the FT

Market summary

Key numbers for investors

	3 Feb 2026	Week before	Change (%)
FTSE 100	10314.59	10207.80	1.05%
FTSE All-share UK	5555.63	5507.98	0.87%
Dow Jones	49019.45	48917.31	0.21%
NASDAQ	23211.24	23841.03	-2.64%
Nikkei 225	54720.66	53333.54	2.60%
Hang Seng	26834.77	27126.95	-1.08%
Gold	4949.17	5085.18	-2.67%
Brent Crude Oil	67.47	66.90	0.85%
DIVIDEND YIELD (FTSE 100)	2.87%	2.88%	
UK 10-year gilts yield	4.62	4.62	
US 10-year Treasuries	4.29	4.22	
UK ECONOMIC DATA			
Latest CPI (yoy)	3.4% (Dec)	3.2% (Nov)	
Latest RPI (yoy)	4.2% (Dec)	3.8% (Nov)	
Halifax house price (yoy)	0.3% (Dec)	0.7% (Nov)	
£1 STERLING:	\$1.371 €1.159 ¥214.482		Bitcoin \$75,827.99

Best and worst performing shares

WEEK'S CHANGE, FTSE 100 STOCKS		
RISES	Price	% change
Anglo American	3700.00	+7.28
Lloyds Banking Group	113.00	+6.98
Vodafone Group	111.00	+5.49
Diageo	1697.00	+5.44
Imperial Brands	3161.00	+4.63
FALLS		
Relx	2214.00	-18.60
London Stock Exchange	7180.00	-13.05
The Sage Group	871.00	-11.98
ICG	1656.00	-11.59
Airtel Africa	324.00	-10.15
FTSE 250 RISER & FALLER		
Saga	578.00	+35.52
HG Capital	405.00	-20.12

Source: FT (not adjusted for dividends). Prices on 3 Feb (pm)

Following the Footsie



6-month movement in the FTSE 100 index

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A century in the wilderness: the Old Believers time forgot

In 1978, Soviet geologists stumbled upon a family living in a remote part of Siberia. Having moved there to escape religious persecution, they hadn't interacted with the outside world for decades. Sophie Pinkham reports

In the summer of 1978, a team of geologists exploring southern Siberia found something rarer than diamonds. While searching for a helicopter-landing site amid the steep hills and forested canyons of the western Sayan Mountains, their pilot caught sight of what appeared to be a garden, 150 miles from the nearest settlement. Hovering as low as he could, he saw a house. No people were visible, but someone was clearly tending the garden. He and his geologist passengers were shocked to find a dwelling in an area long considered too remote for human habitation.

When the four geologists set up camp ten miles away, it was the mysterious homestead that was on their mind. Who could live here? Were the inhabitants the last Mohicans of the Brezhnev era? The team ventured to the settlement bearing gifts – and a pistol, just in case. They were greeted by a dishevelled old man dressed in patched-up sacking cloth. This was Karp Osipovich Lykov, the patriarch of the family. Inside a tiny, dark cabin, the geologists found Karp's two adult daughters, Natalia and Agafia, weeping and praying. Four miles away, by the riverside, lived Karp's two middle-aged sons, Savin and Dmitry. It soon became apparent that no member of this ageing family had interacted with outsiders in decades.

None of the Lykov children had ever seen bread. But when the geologists offered them a loaf and some jam, they refused. "We are not allowed that," they said, in a refrain that would become familiar to all their visitors. Natalia and Agafia were hard to understand, not only because of their archaic vocabulary but also because of an odd, chanting cadence that one geologist described as "a slow, blurred cooing".

The Lykovs were Old Believers, members of the Orthodox Christian schismatic sect whose history is deeply bound up with that of the forest and the countryside. The Old Believers emerged in the mid-17th century after Patriarch Nikon, head of the Russian Orthodox Church, amended the liturgy to bring it into harmony with the Greek Orthodox version. The reforms altered the spelling of "Jesus" – at a time when letters were understood as something close to the literal flesh of God – and changed the number of fingers to be raised when making the sign of the cross from two to three.

Those who rejected these innovations became known as Old Believers. To them, Nikon's reforms were a betrayal of the true Christianity. Their anger was further stoked by the notorious lack of respect for Russian Orthodoxy shown by Peter the Great,



Natalia, Agafia and Karp Lykov in 1980: Natalia died the following year

a self-consciously Westernising tsar. In the early days of the schism, Old Believers were burned alive, tortured and imprisoned for their faith. Many were cast into pits in the ground. Some resorted to self-immolation – whole communities locked themselves in their village churches and set them aflame – while others took refuge in the forest, the safest place to hide from the authorities. Many branches of Old Believers were "priestless", meaning that a family could worship without the help of a professional man of God. For the most radical Old Believers, holiness was directly correlated to isolation.

Although some Russian leaders were conciliatory towards Old Believers – under Catherine the Great, they were

allowed to practise their faith openly – many continued to reject the authority of Church and state, and lived "priestless" in the wilderness. Until the 1920s, Karp's family lived in an Old Believer village in the remote Altai region, a mountainous and forested area of southern Siberia, close to the borders with China and Mongolia. When the Bolsheviks took control and imposed state atheism, even this became unsafe. With four other families, the Lykovs moved upriver, and then in 1934 packed up again, heading on their own to a still wilder location beyond the reach of the increasingly violent authorities. It was there that they were found in 1978, 44 years after leaving civilisation behind. Their

lives, not surprisingly, had been extraordinarily hard. Agafia recalled periods when they'd survived on "rowanberry leaf, roots, grass, mushrooms, potato tops and bark". A late, hard frost in 1961 had resulted in a

family famine, during which the Lykovs had survived on straw, their leather shoes and ski lining, bark and birch buds. The matriarch, Akulina, died of hunger.

When the Lykovs were discovered, they were still furious with Patriarch Nikon and Peter the Great. Karp Osipovich called Peter "the Antichrist in human form". Even the recent wars, known only vaguely to them, were the responsibility of the vile Peter. When the geologists explained the Second World War to Karp, he shook his head dolefully, saying, "What is this, a second time, and always the Germans. A curse on Peter. He flirted with them."

They had outdone themselves in their rejection of Peter's turn to the West. Agafia, the youngest Lykov, had never seen a wheel. The family made fire with a tinderbox. Their only light was the sun or a torch, and they wore birchbark shoes and lived without salt. The family had begun their time in the forest with carrots, but one year all the seeds were eaten by mice. (The carrot seeds

"Agafia, the youngest, had never seen a wheel. The family made fire with a tinderbox. They wore birchbark shoes and lived without salt"

provided by the geologists helped remedy their ghastly white skin, the result of carotene deficiency.) They subsisted on dried potatoes and pine nuts, stored in birchbark containers, as well as turnips, onions, peas and rye. Karp Osipovich thanked God for hemp, potatoes and pine nuts every day. He had overcome the Old Believers' original hatred of potatoes, which had been introduced by Peter the Great and denounced as "a diabolical, abundant, lecherous plant". The Lykovs were proud of their ability to read their smoke-stained Bible, though it was so thoroughly blackened that the words were no longer visible. Akulina had taught her children to read and write in Old Church Slavonic, using a stick dipped in honeysuckle juice to draw blue letters on birch bark.



Agafia: now a national treasure

As the Lykovs reverted from a primarily agricultural life to one closer to that of Neolithic hunter-gatherers, the taiga – as the coniferous forests of Siberia are known – had become an increasingly important source of calories. They drank birch juice and ate wild nettles, wild onions, mushrooms, berries and fish. In late August, the whole family climbed Siberian pines, harvesting nuts. Only when they were very lucky did they manage to catch an animal in their primitive pit traps. Dmitry Lykov was the family's master tracker. He knew all the animal trails and he understood where to dig a snare pit; he was the one who got the first meat for the family, which also meant the first new leather and fur. He tracked Siberian deer and killed them with a pike. He could walk through the snow barefoot and sleep in the forest even in winter, dressed in clothes made from a burlap sack. He brought the others updates about the animals in the taiga, their only substitute for news of the outside world: the grouse whose chicks had hatched, the squirrels huddled together against the cold. He made friends with a bear who took up residence nearby.

But when Dmitry came down with pneumonia, his family refused medical help even when it was offered. They were not allowed that. In autumn 1981, Dmitry, Savin and Natalia all died – Dmitry of pneumonia, and Savin and Natalia of unknown causes: they may have fallen sick because of unfamiliar illnesses introduced by the geologists. Now it was only Karp Osipovich and his daughter Agafia. Karp had hoped to find a husband or another companion to live with Agafia. She spent a happy few weeks with her mother's sisters, who invited her to live permanently with them in their village, but she returned to her father in the taiga. One distant cousin came and lived with her for a while, and they were married – marriage among priestless Old Believers being an enterprise undertaken purely according to the will of the spouses. But they quarrelled about whether to kill a friendly wolf who had befriended Agafia's dog. Agafia felt the wolf was no threat, but her husband disagreed. Soon he returned to town.

The man who made the Lykovs famous was a journalist named Vasily Peskov. After his first article about the Lykovs, published in 1982, he was inundated by letters asking for more news about Karp and Agafia, or sending him gifts and money that he was to bring to them. By the time his detailed, tender book about them was published in 1992, he had been visiting them once or twice a year for a decade. The Lykovs held an endless fascination for the Russian public. They were human buried treasure, Russian Rip van Winkles, living exemplars of a Russia that had disappeared long ago. They had bypassed Stalin's purges and had hardly noticed the Second World War. At the same time, their experience of starvation resonated with some of the most painful episodes in Soviet history. Millions had starved to death during Stalin's

collectivisation of agriculture. During the wartime siege of Leningrad, a whole city had been reduced to boiling shoe leather to survive. Less dramatic forms of deprivation were familiar to almost all readers of newspapers. The Soviet government had never been good at providing a steady supply of high-quality food, and in the second half of the 1980s ration cards were reintroduced.

Both stunningly exotic and remarkably relatable, the taiga family promised the possibility of living entirely outside corrupt, violent, uncertain modernity, and of preserving an ancient form of Russian tradition. Their story marched in step with Russia's sense of national martyrdom, and

with the idea that the more isolated Russia became, the greater its importance in world culture. The perfect emblem of endurance, faith and self-sufficiency, the Old Believers were like an ark, preserving the essence of Russian culture through a great flood of catastrophe and modernisation.

As Agafia and her father grew older, it became impossible for them to live without help. They grew bolder in their requests of assistance and relaxed their old rules, dressing in the clothes they were given (though only if they were brand new; used clothes were prohibited because of a fear of contamination). They traded candles for flashlights, cleaned the floor and their faces, and installed a hand-crank meat grinder. They began using enamelled pots painted with brightly coloured berries.

"Agafia's friends gave her an SOS button that she could use to summon a helicopter if she became ill; she began to abuse the privilege"

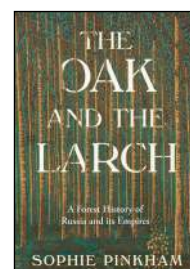
After Karp died in 1988, Agafia remained in the forest. She began to resemble a former dancing bear moved to a wildlife enclosure. The illusion of her independence came to rely on constant interventions from the

outside world. Agafia's friends gave her an SOS button she could use to summon a helicopter if she became ill, but she began to abuse the privilege. Someone had to explain to her how much it cost to send a helicopter. It was the 1990s, the Russian economy was in tatters, and there was no money left to pay her bills.

Now in her early 80s, Agafia still lives in the area, although her life is very different to how it was. A new cabin was built for her in 2021 with the support of the oligarch Oleg Deripaska, who owns several aluminium plants in Siberia. She is assisted by an Old Believer novice from Moscow; unlike the hermits of old, the pair have a telephone to facilitate communication with the press and rescue services. One former regional governor complained recently that Agafia's upkeep, notably the delivery of groceries by helicopter, was costing the state millions of rubles, and that it was illegal to live in a national park. But Agafia's status as a national treasure, the last member of an endangered species, outweighs such concerns.

On YouTube, Agafia, the woman who spent much of her life without bread or wheels, is a paradoxical superstar. Videos about her garner millions of views. There is even an unconvincing AI-generated account in her name that pretends to be her own video diary. Her popularity testifies to the allure of self-sufficiency in the wilderness – even as the last chapters of her story show that long-term survival alone in the taiga is only a fantasy.

Extracted from *The Oak and the Larch: A Forest History of Russia and its Empires* by Sophie Pinkham, published by William Collins at £25 © Sophie Pinkham 2026



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Two Connell Guides and three Week-branded items will be given to the sender of the first correct solution to the crossword and the clue of the week opened on Monday 16 February. Send it to The Week Crossword 1502, 121-141 Westbourne Terrace, London W2 6JR, or email the completed grid/listed solutions to crossword@theweek.co.uk. By **Paul McKenna**



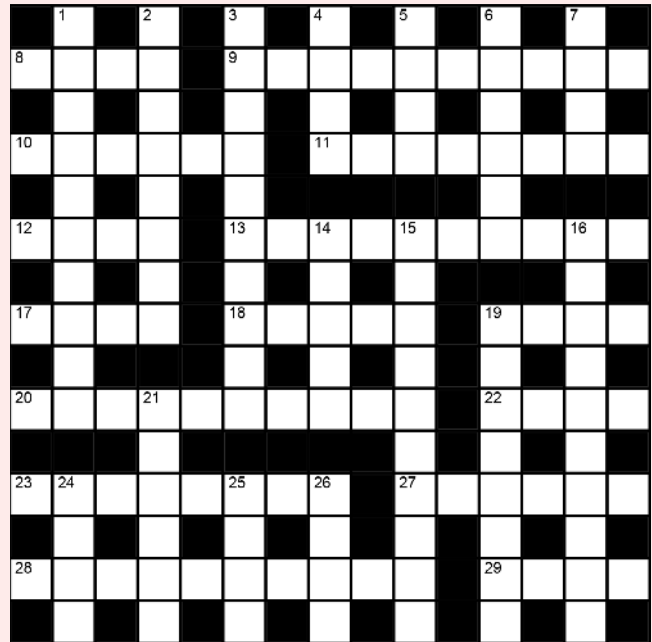
This week's winner will receive Week-branded items, as well as two Connell Guides (connellguides.com).

ACROSS

- 8 Time to copy video (4)
9 Something for the summer term, struggling with Tai Chi (10)
10 Dad ain't changing coat due to age? (6)
11 Minute, like the three blind mice? (8)
12 Feature of sand, unending (4)
13 What comes from Parma that's tough? (4,6)
17 Somewhat more than half tipsy? That's perhaps arguable (4)
18 Pace set by the vacuous parliamentarian? Nul (5)
19 Following mineral you'll get a warning (4)
20 Get subordinate to rise (10)
22 Cruise giving son bother (4)
23 Driver, e.g., would be around in one of these (4,4)
27 Complains having nothing to do with gross entrails (6)
28 British fool rings those blowing their own trumpets (5,5)
29 Stand for chap accepting prize finally (4)

DOWN

- 1 Scruffy imp, kid with a breakfast roll? (10)
2 Food store remarkably makes shipment (8)
3 Drops a cup with her sat awkwardly (10)
4 Current victory day (4)
5 Bar in small shack (4)
6 Cold English spring is pinky red (6)
7 Dreadful day suppressing anger (4)
14 Odd degree in dance music (5)
15 Caught by bold fly in shower (10)
16 Bloke supporting sermon on depravity for a soldier (10)
19 Greeting female, one born to enter puzzle (4-4)
21 Inconsiderate, first to go – like the one on the shelf? (6)
24 Good King on a vegetable (4)
25 Shy? Finally nibble bit of the ear (4)
26 Secure box with diamonds (4)



Name _____
Address _____
Tel no _____
Clue of the week answer: _____

Clue of the week: One who's flown abroad as a result of regime change (6)
The Times

Solution to Crossword 1500

ACROSS: 9 Antipasti 10 Anode 11 Née 12 Nursing home 13 Catch it 14 Inhabit 16 Exclamation mark 20 Sangria 21 Olympia 23 Accelerando 25 Ass 26 Arson 27 Mont Blanc

DOWN: 1 Barnacle 2 Street 3 Up in the air 4 Esprit 5 Piri-piri 6 Bang 7 Colombia 8 Regent 15 Honeycombs 17 Cynicism 18 Anagrams 19 Knapsack 20 Shaman 21 Owning 22 Play at 24 Land

Clue of the week: Creature featured in pop song (6)
Solution: WEASEL

The winner of 1500 is **Ruth Carson-Byrne from Stockport**

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	7		3		8		5	
9	4						3	8
		8				9		
4				2				6
			6		4			
1			7					5
		1				8		
8	6						2	9
	3		8		9		1	

Sudoku 1,044 (medium)

Fill in all the squares so that each row, column and each of the 3x3 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9

Solution to Sudoku 1,043

7	6	9	5	4	3	1	8	2
2	4	8	7	1	9	3	5	6
1	5	3	2	8	6	7	4	9
3	7	4	6	5	2	8	9	1
5	9	1	4	7	8	6	2	3
8	2	6	9	3	1	4	7	5
6	8	5	1	9	7	2	3	4
4	3	2	8	6	5	9	1	7
9	1	7	3	2	4	5	6	8

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Charity of the week



The Outside Project is an LGBTQ+ Community Centre and Shelter, and Domestic Abuse Refuge for those within the LGBTQ+ community who feel endangered, and who also feel that they are on the outside of services owing to historical and present prejudice in society and in their homes. Since the Covid emergency response and the founding of one of the UK's first LGBTQ+ domestic abuse refuges in 2020, the organisation works tirelessly to address the absence of LGBTQ+ crisis housing for London's estimated half a million LGBTQ+ population. Visit lgbtqioutside.org for more information.



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